



Hindustan Times

GLITCHES CITED IN AIR INDIA FLIGHT INCIDENT, AIRBUS TO ASSIST PROBE

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NEW DELHI: Airbus on Monday said it was sending specialists to assist an investigation into the sudden altitude loss of an Air India A320neo aircraft last week, even as people familiar with the matter cited a preliminary defect report (PDR) prepared by the pilots to suggest that the incident was preceded by multiple technical glitches, including an autopilot disconnection.

With the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) commencing its probe into the August 4 incident, teams from the French air accident investigation agency, Bureau of Enquiry and Analysis for Civil Aviation Safety (BEA), as well as the aircraft's manufacturer Airbus will assist in the investigation, as per the standard operating procedures. →P9

Delhi Aug rain already in excess with 3 weeks to go

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NEW DELHI: A brief spell of showers in Delhi on Monday helped push the quantum of showers this August past the weather department's long-period average for the month, which still has three weeks to go, underscoring what has been an unusually wet spell for the Capital deep into the monsoon. The Safdarjung station - considered Delhi's representative weather gauge - clocked just 4mm of rain on Monday, enough to drive the month's total to 234.5mm, past the India Meteorological Department's (IMD) long-period average (LPA) of 233.1mm for the month.

This is the earliest rains in Delhi have crossed the mark in at least 15 years, with just seven days of showers in the first 10 days of the month.



Last year, Delhi clocked a significant rain surplus, with 400.81mm of precipitation between August 1 and 31, but it crossed the LPA only on August 15, after 11 days of rain. In 2024, the city took one more day to reach the same mark, crossing the LPA on August 16, after 13 days of rain.

The consistent rainy days have helped keep temperatures in the city in check this month with day temperatures hovering near the normal range, and even falling below it. On August 6 and 7, the maximum temperature stood at 27.6°C and 27.5°C, respectively, over 6 degrees below

continued on →P9

Kanwar camps trigger traffic mayhem



A traffic jam on Outer Ring Road near Bhalswa due to arrangements for kanwariyas on Monday. →P11

RESIDENTS NEAR CAMPS FACE MUSIC
People living next to temporary camps for kanwariyas have borne the most immediate brunt of the ongoing yatras: days of blaring music, rattling windows, disrupted sleep and clogged neighbourhood roads.

SLEEP, WORK, SCHOOL LIFE WRECKED
Residents report shattered sleep, disrupted work and school routines, blocked roads, piled-up garbage, and safety fears from kanwariyas carrying sticks - with complaints to the police hardly yielding any lasting action.

DHAKA AGAIN RAISES HASINA EXTRADITION AS INDIAN ENVOY MEETS PM RAHMAN

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: Bangladesh on Monday called on India to speed up the extradition of former premier Sheikh Hasina and to create an environment conducive to advancing bilateral ties as PM Tarique Rahman met Indian envoy Dinesh Trivedi in Dhaka to take stock of relations. →P2

FIRING AT DISPUTED ARUNACHAL-ASSAM BORDER INJURES 12

SILCHAR: At least 12 Assam villagers were allegedly injured, three critically, after unidentified people opened fire along the interstate border with Arunachal Pradesh on Monday, police said. The two states share more than 800 km of border, parts of which are disputed and have been the source of clashes. →P8

SC orders FIRs for all missing people, warns states, UTs of contempt

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed all states and UTs to immediately register FIRs whenever a person goes missing, irrespective of age or gender, expressing "shock" that some states were under the impression its earlier order applied to missing children. A bench of justices Alinauddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan termed the interpretation a "deliberate and mala fide bogey" and held that chief secretaries and DGPs of states and UTs found to have failed to comply with its May 22 order would face contempt proceedings and be required to remain personally present before the court to explain the lapses. "We are shocked to learn that some of the States are under the impression that the expression 'person' refers only to children and does not include adults. We find

COURT TERMED INTERPRETATION OF MAY 22 ORDER TO MISSING PERSONS A 'DELIBERATE AND MALA FIDE BOGEY'

this to be a deliberate and mala fide bogey raised by such states," the bench said in its August 5 order, released on Monday. Making it clear that there was no ambiguity in its earlier direction, the bench said: "...The expression 'person' means every person, irrespective of age or gender."

In its earlier order, the court directed every police station to immediately register an FIR the moment information was received about "any person missing", with out waiting for a preliminary inquiry or asking the family to first search for the missing person. →P6

35-YR-OLD KILLS HIS TWO DAUGHTERS, ATTEMPTS SUICIDE AT 5-STAR HOTEL

Coovercolly Indresh
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BENGALURU: A 35-year-old man allegedly strangled his two daughters, aged five and 10, to death before attempting suicide in a room at a five-star hotel near Bengaluru's Kempegowda International Airport on Monday, police said.

Police said they found a purported suicide note in the room in which the man referred to an argument with his wife and accused her of cheating. "The contents of the note are being examined..." said DCP GK Mithun Kumar. →P7

GGM: CAMELLIAS RESIDENT HELP FOR ASSAULTING HER HOUSE HELP

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GURUGRAM: A 52-year-old woman - a resident of the upscale DLF Camellias high-rises in Gurugram - was arrested on Monday for allegedly assaulting her 22-year-old house help and confining her at the residence, police said. The matter came to light after a 90-second video of the incident, reportedly shot by an occupant of an adjacent building, was widely shared on social media.

18 SHORTLISTED FOR RAM TEMPLE CEO; INTERVIEWS START FROM TODAY

AYODHYA: The selection process for the first CEO of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust will enter its final stage on Tuesday, with a three-member panel interviewing 18 shortlisted candidates from 5,200 applicants, trust members said on Monday. The interviews will be held at the conference room of the temple's pilgrim facilitation centre and will be conducted behind closed doors. The panel will recommend three candidates to the Trust, which will make the final selection. →P5

SWOLLEN DRAIN SWEEPS AWAY VAN IN RAJGARH; NINE OF FAMILY KILLED

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BHOPAL: Nine members of a family, including four children, died after a van was swept away while crossing a flooded drain in Madhya Pradesh's Rajgarh district on Monday, officials said, adding that two people from the vehicle have been rescued. "Despite repeated warnings from locals, the driver attempted to cross. The strong current swept the van into the drain within minutes," said SDO Arvind Singh. →P6

{ TO BE SUNG AS PM ARRIVES }

Full Vande Mataram to ring out from Red Fort for 1st time on I-Day

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NEW DELHI: The national song Vande Mataram will be sung from the ramparts of the Red Fort for the first time at this year's Independence Day celebrations, which will focus on 150 years of the song and the contribution of young Indians to the goal of a Viksit Bharat by 2047, defence secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh said on Monday. Around 27,000 people are expected to attend the 80th Independence Day celebrations, with youth, innovators, entrepreneurs and students among those invited.

THE THEMES OF THE CELEBRATIONS WILL BE 150 YRS OF VANDE MATARAM AND YUVA SHAKTI FOR VIKSIT BHARAT@2047

Singh said at a media briefing. Vande Mataram will be sung in full when Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrives at the Red Fort, after which he will hoist the national flag and deliver his customary address to the nation. Invitation cards

TAMIL NADU ASSEMBLY PASSES RESOLUTION ON STATE ANTHEM

The Tamil Nadu assembly on Monday unanimously passed a resolution mandating that the state anthem be played at the start of government events in the state. "Tamil is not just a language, but also our life and emotions. The Tamil Thai Vaazhthu, which upholds the diversity of entire India, must hold the primary place here in Tamil Nadu," chief minister and TVK leader Vijay said in the assembly. →P6



continued on →2

NUMBER THEORY

PART 1

Samudra Manthan, petroleum and India's energy security policy

By Shreya Khandelwal

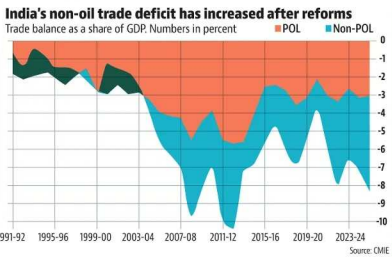
On July 31, the Union Cabinet approved the National Offshore Exploration Scheme (Samudra Manthan), a central sector scheme of the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, with an outlay of ₹84,084 crore over the next five years. The scheme aims to increase India's petroleum production by unlocking its "vast offshore hydrocarbon potential". Broad components of the scheme are seismic data acquisition, processing and interpretation, accelerating offshore exploration, creating common offshore infrastructure and deploying modern technology, and developing and strengthening oil and gas manufacturing and services zones in the country. These efforts, the government believes, will

increase India's hydrocarbon resource base from 1.6 billion to 2.2 billion tonnes of Oil Equivalent (TOE), increase output to a peak potential of 20 million metric tonnes of Oil Equivalent (MMTOE), lower the import bill by up to ₹1 lakh crore each year, and promote investment, employment and manufacturing. While petroleum is an important component of India's energy requirements and needs import-substitution measures, safeguarding India's energy security requires going beyond petroleum. This two-part series will explain this argument in detail. The first part will discuss the trade aspect of India's petroleum economy, while the second will address the larger energy-security picture.



1 India's oil trade deficit has lost its importance in the overall trade deficit

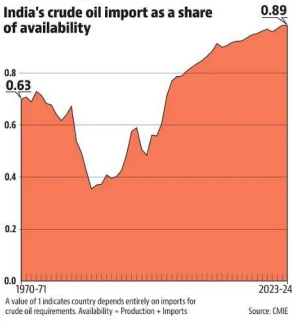
Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) data provides a breakdown of India's petroleum-oil-lubricants (POL) and non-POL merchandise trade deficits. As a share of GDP — an absolute comparison is not meaningful because the economy has grown in size — the non-POL deficit has become more significant during India's post-reform period.



2 Import dependence in quantitative terms has increased...

What makes oil an important and critical commodity is not just its price. Securing its physical availability can also become a challenge because of extra-economic factors. Developments in the past few years — first the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022 and, now, the ongoing West Asia war, which has disrupted traffic through the Strait of Hormuz and petroleum supplies passing through it — are painful reminders of this reality. Securing actual barrels is where India's energy

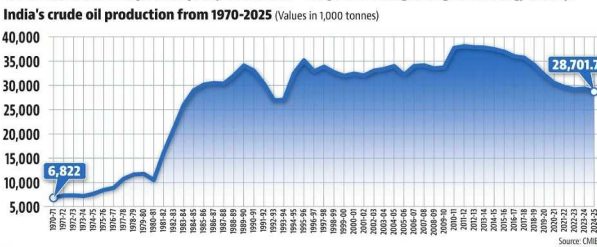
import dependence has increased, whether viewed from the demand side or the supply side. CMIE data shows that crude oil imports, as a share of total availability in India — availability being production plus net imports — are about 90%, according to the latest available data. This number has been increasing consistently for a long time. There has also been an increase from the supply side. India's imports, as a share of global crude oil production, are also significantly higher now.



3 ... while domestic crude oil production has actually fallen

According to CMIE data, crude oil production in India increased between 1970 and 1990. This was followed by a stall and then a fall in production. While India can never hope to completely overcome its

import dependence for petroleum, it should not give up on import substitution either. This is why efforts to boost domestic petroleum production are an important component of safeguarding India's energy security.



The numbers and arguments presented here underline the logic behind the Samudra Manthan Scheme but represent only a partial picture of any strategy to safeguard India's energy security. Making the strategy more holistic requires incorporating India's overall energy requirements and their future drivers. The second part of this series will attempt to do exactly this.



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Shah to reply on student protests in House: Rijiju

Oppn also seeks discussion on Ram Temple case; govt accuses Rahul Gandhi of 'shifting goalpost'

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: The government on Monday offered to debate students' issues and police action in Parliament with a reply by Union home minister Amit Shah, in a last-ditch effort to end the two-week-long logjam, but the Opposition insisted on specific responses and a second debate on donation theft in the Ram Temple.

In a meeting of the Lok Sabha's Business Advisory Committee (BAC) chaired by speaker Om Birla, parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju made the offer. Birla, too, appealed to the Opposition to cooperate in the smooth conduct of proceedings, pointing out that the government agreed on the main demand of the Opposition — a statement by Shah.

"We have made it clear to the BAC of the Lok Sabha that the government is ready for a full-fledged discussion on the stu-

dent and youth agitations that have been going on in different parts of the country as well as police action. The home minister will give point-by-point reply to the debate on behalf of the government," Rijiju said after the BAC meeting.

Pointing out that the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi had demanded that Shah make a statement in Parliament on the student protests, Rijiju said, "We have made our offer. Now, there appear to be some differences between the Congress and the Samajwadi Party — which they need to resolve. As for the student issue, we are ready for a discussion. We have stated our position. Now, it is up to the Samajwadi Party and the Congress to sort out the differences between the Opposition — a statement by Shah.

morestories

FM: No UPI fee for users; Parl clears Bankers' Books Bill →P12

"We are not interested in any fantasy statements from [Amit] Shah. He has to clarify who authorised the shooting at youngsters in Delhi... They were beaten with lathi with nails. Shah is guilty of either negligence or of culpability and he must resign."

— RAHUL GANDHI, LoP in Lok Sabha

"When the home minister agreed to his demand, the Congress leader changed his goalpost... I want to state clearly, Rahul Gandhi, do not run away from the discussion. We are ready. We are prepared to discuss every issue inside the House."

— JP NADDA, Union health minister

Now, Nagaland CM raises FCRA concerns with Shah

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NEW DELHI: Nagaland chief minister Nephthi Rio wrote to Union home minister Amit Shah expressing concerns over proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), becoming the third CM from the Northeast to flag the controversial proposals. →P5

KWATRA DEFENDS FCRA

Amid criticism from some US lawmakers about proposed changes to India's FCRA, Indian Ambassador to the US Vinay Kwatra took to X in an effort to counter what he said were misperceptions about the amendments. He said FCRA mirrored similar attempts in other countries to regulate the flow of foreign funds into the country. →P5

BILL TO CURB STATES' TAXES ON MINERAL RIGHTS Tabled

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NEW DELHI: The government on Monday introduced an amendment bill in the Lok Sabha that seeks to restrict state governments from imposing taxes, cesses or levies on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands, saying excessive and unpredictable taxation would make the sector commercially unviable. →P5

SON OF INDIRA ASSASSINATION CONVICT TO STAND IN PUNJAB POLLS

HT Correspondent
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AMRITSAR: Akali Dal (Wartar Punjab De), the party of jailed Khaddor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh, on Monday named Satwant Singh as its first candidate for the upcoming Punjab assembly elections. Satwant is the son of Kehar Singh, who was convicted of conspiring to assassinate former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi and later hanged. →P7



Police and student protesters face off during a march to the assembly in Ranchi on Monday.

Protesters, cops clash during J'khand march

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RANCHI: Thousands of students protesting against alleged irregularities in Jharkhand state recruitment exams clashed with the police as they attempted to march to the state assembly in Ranchi on Monday, leaving four agitators and three policemen injured.

Protesters — who have been agitating at the Jai Pal Singh Munda Stadium against irregu-

larities in recruitment examinations conducted by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) for the last 17 days — started at 10.40am and reached the assembly gates by 6pm, braving lathi-charge, tear gas and water cannons.

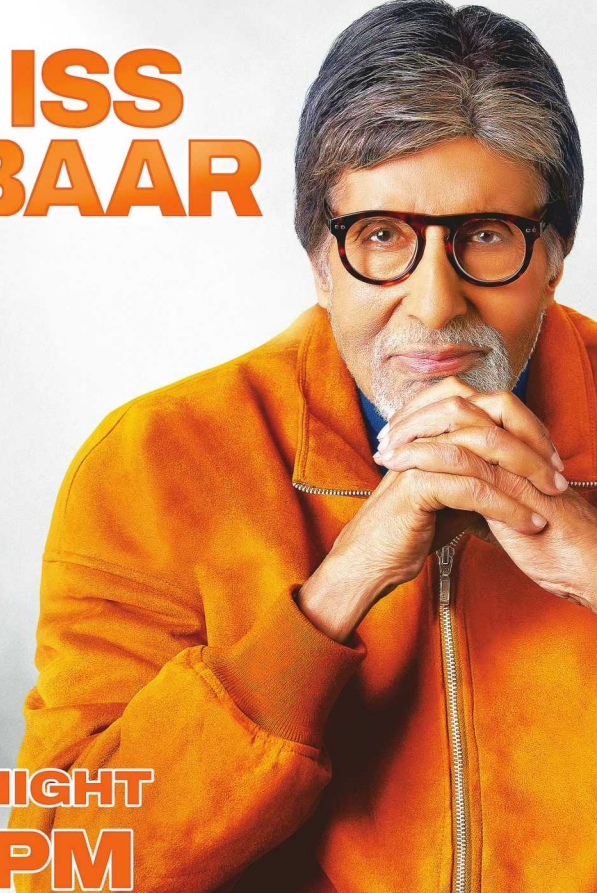
The developments came on a day the state police's Crime Investigation Department (CID) arrested former JPSC chairman

ED FILES PMLA CASE IN EXAM IRREGULARITIES

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has filed a money-laundering case to probe alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission examinations, people familiar with the matter said, as protests and an indefinite hunger strike in Ranchi entered the 17th day on Monday. Officials said ED may interrogate those arrested in the case. The PMLA case stems from the Jharkhand Police's first information report. →P5

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MY INDIA JOURNALIST'S MURDER

SC to hear plea against Ram Rahim acquittal



The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to hear a plea against the Punjab and Haryana HC order acquitting Dera Sacha Sauda chief Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh in the 2017 murder case of a journalist. This matter requires consideration, a bench comprising CJ Surya Kant and Justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V Mohana said. The apex court posted the plea filed by the son of the slain journalist, for final hearing on August 17. The 58-year-old Dera chief is currently lodged in Bahak's Sunaria jail where he is serving a 20-year jail term given in 2017 for the rape of two of his disciples. Journalist Ram Chander Chhatrapati was shot outside his house after his newspaper published an anonymous letter narrating the alleged sexual exploitation of women followers at the Dera headquarters in Sirsa.

SPORT AT BWF C'SHIP VENUE

Langur mimics hired to fend off monkeys



To prevent any disruptions during the BWF World Championships, set to begin on August 17, authorities have hired men who could mimic the sound of an angry langur to chase away monkeys from the venue, the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium in New Delhi. The three men have been hired to stand outside offices or sporting arenas and make the aggressive langur noise. "When we make these calls, monkeys just run away. We also ensure that monkeys don't run into people or cars, etc. We time the mimicking accordingly. This vocal method is quite effective," one of the men said. The move comes after monkeys strayed into the playing hall during the India Open in January.

WORLD HOPES FOR DEAL TO OPEN HORMUZ FAE

Iran must pay compensation for those it has killed: Trump



US President Donald Trump on Monday demanded Iran pay compensation for the deaths of people he said it had killed in wars, attacks and protests, raising the rhetorical stakes with Tehran as hopes faded for an imminent deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Trump said he was responding to Iran's earlier call for Washington to meet conditions, including recompensing Tehran for the damage caused in the more than five months since the US and Israel launched strikes on its territory. "I am likewise demanding compensation from Iran, for all of the people that they have killed and gravely wounded with their roadside bombs and many conflicts, for which they are famous," Trump wrote on his Truth Social page. Trump said the demand would be included in all future negotiations with Iran.

BUSINESS HIGHER USER REVENUE

Vodafone Idea Q1 loss narrows to ₹3.7k-cr



Debt-ridden telecom firm Vodafone Idea on Monday reported a narrowing of loss to ₹3,754 crore in the first quarter of FY2027 mainly on account of relaxation given by the government on dues and a notional gain in price of shares earmarked for it by a promoter group. The company had posted a net loss of ₹6,611 crore in the period a year ago, according to an exchange filing by the telecom company. The finance cost of Vodafone Idea (VI) declined by 13% to ₹5,020 crore during the reporting period from ₹5,893 crore in the June quarter of last year. Vodafone Idea under a pact with one of its promoters, Vodafone Group, qualified to get around ₹5,836 crore as part of a liability claim pact between the two companies.

WORLD IN U.S.

Court allows suits on social media addiction



US appeals court on Monday allowed thousands of lawsuits to move forward against Meta Platforms, Alphabet's Google, ByteDance's TikTok, and other social media companies over claims they designed their products to be addictive to young users. The San Francisco-based 9th US Circuit Court of Appeals rejected the companies' bid to reverse a lower court's ruling forcing them to face more than 3,000 lawsuits over the claims filed in federal court, concluding that the appeal came too early in the litigation. The court also denied Meta's bid to postpone a trial beginning Wednesday in a lawsuit brought by 29 state attorneys general alleging that the company illegally collected and used children's data, designed their social media platforms to keep young users hooked, and misled consumers about their safety.

Hasina, ties in focus as envoy meets B'desh PM

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: Bangladesh on Monday called on India to expedite the extradition of former premier Sheikh Hasina and create an environment conducive to advancing bilateral ties as Prime Minister Tarique Rahman met Indian envoy Dinesh Trivedi in Dhaka to take stock of relations.

Dhaka reiterated its request for Hasina's extradition five days after the former PM held a virtual news conference from New Delhi to discuss her plans to return to Bangladesh in December.

Hasina has lived in self-exile in India since fleeing Bangladesh in August 2024, and her presence in the country remains a key irritant in bilateral relations.

Trivedi paid a "courtesy call" on Tarique Rahman at the Prime Minister's Office in Dhaka, where "important bilateral issues" were discussed, according to a readout from the Bangladesh government. It was the first meeting between the PM and Trivedi, a political appointee who was sent to Dhaka about two months ago.

"Bangladesh hopes that India will expedite the process of extraditing Sheikh Hasina," the readout, issued in Bengali, said.

Tarique Rahman "emphasised the need to create a conducive environment to further advance relations between the two countries," it said.

Foreign minister Khalibur Rahman, who attended the meeting along with the Prime Minister's adviser on foreign affairs, Humayun Kobar, later told reporters that the issue of "extradition of the convicted fugitive Sheikh Hasina came up



Indian envoy Dinesh Trivedi (right) with Bangladeshi PM Tarique Rahman.

and we told them to expedite the extradition".

He added, "We hope that India will respond positively on this issue."

Khalibur Rahman said the Indian side had understood Bangladesh's position on Hasina.

"Sheikh Hasina is a convicted person," he said, adding that her news conference in New Delhi on August 5 undermined the judiciary, one of the pillars of the state of Bangladesh.

"And the government of India allowed her to do that," he said.

"We hope they will not do anything in the future that undermines any of the pillars of our state. That is our expectation."

Khalibur Rahman further said the Bangladesh government was yet to take a decision on two invitations extended by India to the PM — for a bilateral visit and to attend the Brics Summit in September.

Dhaka also reiterated its request for the handover of two Bangladeshi nationals arrested in India on suspicion of involvement in the killing of Bangladeshi politician Sharif Osman Hadi.

"The suspected killers of Hadi have been caught. We have provided all the documents that

were sought by India... This is a very sensitive issue for us and we said these suspected killers should be extradited to us as quickly as possible," Khalibur Rahman said, speaking in Bengali.

The two Bangladeshi nationals were arrested in West Bengal in March for alleged involvement in the killing of Hadi, who was shot by gunmen in Dhaka last December and subsequently died while being treated in Singapore.

The attack sparked violent protests across Bangladesh that assumed anti-India overtones because of unsubstantiated reports of an Indian link to Hadi's killing.

Trivedi separately told the media that all issues between India and Bangladesh can be addressed through talks. "I can confidently say that there are no issues that we can't sit down together and resolve," he said.

"We are both vibrant democracies and the people of both countries want good relations — that is natural."

Trivedi said he had "very good discussions" with Tarique Rahman and both sides are "looking forward". He noted that there is a standing invitation for Tarique Rahman to visit India and a meeting between the two PMs will help take the relationship forward.

"You can't change history or our neighbourhood. We don't only share the border, we share dreams and I believe the future will be good. We have to sort out the issues. I am very confident," Trivedi said.

Trivedi left for New Delhi shortly after his meeting with the Bangladeshi PM.

'Avada Kedavra': Potterheads force cable diversion

A fan backlash linked to the memorial of beloved Harry Potter character Dobby has led to the rerouting of a key power cable

BRITAIN-IRELAND POWER LINK

£430mn
Cost of cable
200km
Its length

The Greenlink interconnector, an over-and-under-sea cable project, links Britain's National Grid with Ireland. Its original route was planned to pass through the area of a memorial to Dobby at Freshwater West beach in Pembrokeshire, Wales.



FROM FILM SET TO FAN SHRINE

Freshwater West became a revered site for Harry Potter fans because it was the setting for Dobby's death scene in the movie Harry Potter and The Deathly Hallows: Part 1. Visitors began leaving pebbles and stones inscribed with "Here Lies Dobby," as well as socks as tributes to the character. The National Trust, which owns the beach, agreed in 2022 that the memorial could remain but urged visitors not to leave souvenirs because the site is ecologically sensitive.

CASTING A PROTEST SPELL

When fans discovered the proposed cable route could pass through the memorial, project manager Simon Ludlam told The Guardian his company received "hundreds of calls". Ludlam said he initially did not know who Dobby was. Planners subsequently worked on a new route to avoid the memorial.

A BRONZE AGE PLOT TWIST

The diverted cable came close to genuine Bronze Age remains. Pembrokeshire council planning documents said archaeological trenches near the underground cable contained the rim of an inverted pottery vessel believed to be a Bronze Age collar urn dating to around 1700-1500BC, typically associated with human burial. The cable ultimately avoided both Dobby's memorial and the archaeological remains.



DOBBY: THE REVERED HOUSE ELF

Dobby is a fictional house elf from the Harry Potter series who dies while helping Harry and his friends escape danger. Originally enslaved by the Malfoy family, he becomes a loyal ally of Harry and repeatedly helps the group.

7.4-magnitude earthquake rocks Colombia, killing 11

Reuters

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BOGOTA: At least 11 people were killed after a powerful earthquake struck western Colombia early on Monday morning, knocking down buildings across several cities and injuring 87 more, with still others trapped in the rubble.

The quake struck just days after Abalo de La Esprilla was sworn in as president, thrusting the new administration into its first major crisis, with aftershocks still fresh from devastating twin earthquakes in neighboring Venezuela in June.

The 7.4 magnitude quake, according to the U.S. Geological Survey, struck at a depth of 107km near San Jose del Palmar, in Choco, a sparsely populated province on Colombia's Pacific coast, but was felt in major cities nationwide.

"Significant casualties and damage are likely and the disaster is potentially widespread," the quake warned.

The highest reported death toll was in the western province of Risaralda in Colombia's coffee-growing region, where Governor Juan Diego Pardo, speaking by phone to Caracol Television, reported 42 fatalities.

In the province's capital of Pereira, social media images showed a building with a cracked facade crash to the ground.



Residents and rescue workers search through the rubble of a collapsed building in Cali, Colombia, on Monday.

ground, sending up a dark cloud of dust and debris as onlookers on the street stared away.

The impact also toppled one of the towers atop a Gothic-style cathedral in Manizales, and forced nurses in Cali to wheel patients outside in hospital beds, social media and television images showed.

In nearby Manizales, Mayor Jorge Eduardo Rojas said three people were killed.

One person died in Buenaventura, Colombia's main Pacific port, when a building collapsed, trapping several people.

People remained trapped in Cali, one of Colombia's largest cities, after more than two dozen

structures collapsed, Mayor Alejandro Eder said. He added that the city had asked authorities in Bogota and Medellin to send disaster teams to support rescue efforts.

"At this point, two people have already been rescued alive, one elderly woman and one young girl. There are more people trapped," Eder told Blu Radio. "We have at least 12 critical points and 25 collapsed structures that we are responding to."

Choco Governor Nubia Carolina Cordoba-Curi said there were injuries and significant damage in Quibdo, the provincial capital, and warned residents about aftershocks.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

I-DAY CELEBRATIONS

issued by the defence ministry carry the lyrics of the song so that attendees can sing along.

The celebration will be held under two themes — "150 Years of Vande Mataram" and "Yuva Shakti for Viksit Bharat@2047". Singh said the Yuva Shakti theme was decided independently of the recent developments at Jantar Mantra.

The youth invited to the celebrations include innovators under national innovation programmes, top interns under the Prime Minister's Internship Scheme, start-ups and entrepreneurs under various government schemes, and youth who have performed well under the Prime Minister's Kaushal Vikas Yojana and Start-up India Seed Fund.

The defence ministry said 19 students who won medals at the International Physics, Chemistry, Biology and Mathematical Olympiads 2026 have also been invited. Their achievements, it said, exemplify the success of Yuva Shakti in science.

The Vande Mataram theme will also be reflected in the ceremonial arrangements.

The floral decoration will showcase "Vande Mataram" with a total of 2,500 boy and girl caddets of NCC and My Bharat volunteers forming Vande Mataram on Gyan Path. A Mi-17 helicopter of the Indian Air Force will carry a banner commemorating 150 years of "Vande Mataram", and shower flower petals over the people gathered at Red Fort," the

THE DECISION TO FEATURE VANDE MATARAM PROMINENTLY COMES AMID A RENEWED GOVT FOCUS ON THE NATIONAL SONG IN ITS 150TH YEAR

defence ministry said.

The ministry said view-corders in the backdrop would showcase India's progress in nuclear and space technology.

The prevention of protests in the Guard of Honour area would depict India's journey towards Viksit Bharat@2047.

The decision to feature Vande Mataram prominently at the celebrations comes amid a renewed government focus on the national song in its 150th year.

In February, the Union home ministry issued protocols providing for rendition of all six stanzas of the song at specified official functions.

Parliament recently passed a bill elevating the national song to the same status as the national anthem.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, makes any obstruction or insult to the national song a criminal offence, proposing a jail term of up to three years and a fine for offenders.

The law currently safeguards the national flag, the national anthem and the Constitution.

'Courts must not allow attire to be used to blame women'

Shruti Kakkar

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Monday strongly condemned the "regressive" and "troubling" mindset that a woman wearing jeans could "corrupt young boys" and added that a woman's choice of attire cannot be invoked during cross-examination to question her character or shift blame onto her.

The choice of clothing also does not justify any unlawful conduct, a bench of Justice Chandrachud said, adding that the society must learn to regulate their own conduct, respect personal boundaries and treat every individual with dignity.

"Woman's choice of attire neither diminishes her dignity nor serves as justification or condonation for unlawful conduct directed against her. Questions founded upon regressive notions of how a woman ought to dress have no legitimate place in a court of law and cannot be permitted to become a device for character assassination or for blaming the prosecutrix," the judge said in a 50-page verdict.

The court passed the order in an appeal against the trial court's August 2024 verdict acquitting a man in a sexual assault case.

The appeal stemmed from a July 2023 incident in which the man allegedly made sexual remarks on a 17-year-old girl and

Woman's choice of attire neither diminishes her dignity nor serves as justification or condonation for unlawful conduct...

committed aggravated sexual assault by touching her cheek and hip. Before the trial court, he argued that the complaint, the girl, with the help of a police sub-inspector with whom she was allegedly in a relationship, falsely implicated him due to his criminal antecedents.

The court, however, said clothing is a "personal choice". "Neither her neighbours, nor society, nor the accused, nor counsel appearing in a court of law has any right to dictate her clothing. It is simply none of their concern."

The court, while setting aside the acquittal of the man booked under the Pco Act, also strongly criticised the line of questioning taken by the defence counsel during cross-examination and arguments which had

focused on the residents of the "Muslim area" being orthodox and the clothes that the girl generally wore.

Such questions, the court said, were "wholly irrelevant" and aimed at humiliating and morally judging the prosecutrix, adding that they should have been disallowed by the trial judge at the outset.

"The process of cross-examination cannot be reduced to an instrument of humiliation, nor can the dignity of a witness be sacrificed under the guise of testing her credibility," the judge said.

She further said there was "no reason whatsoever" to bring religion into the case, emphasising that the Indian Penal Code, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (Pco) Act and all other laws apply equally to every person, irrespective of religion.

In the judgment, the court emphasised that judicial officers must ensure that court proceedings do not become a second source of trauma for victims or witnesses.

"The right of an accused to a fair trial must be fully protected, but it cannot be allowed to become a means of subjecting a witness to indignity or character assassination," the court said.

DELHI HIGH COURT

July 29, 2024, the Deputy Commissioner directed the Humnabad Tahsildar to seal nine industries allegedly responsible for pollution.

Humnabad BJP MLA Siddhalingappa Patil said residents of his constituency had been dealing with industrial pollution for nearly 15 years and that he had repeatedly sought government action. "In my constituency, people have been suffering from chemical factory pollution for nearly 15 years, and I urged the government to take strict action," Patil said.

He said that when Khanderi was serving as the state forest minister, a committee had been formed and more than 14 chemical factories were shut down. Patil said the pollution had since spread to nearby villages.

Savarkar row: BJP says IJML misusing power

Vishnu Varma

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A day after a school teacher was suspended over a controversial question on right-wing ideology VD Savarkar in a quiz competition, the BJP on Monday alleged that the Indian Union Muslim League (IJML), whose minister is in charge of the education department, is "misusing power to punish teachers who teach historic facts".

Guru Prasad, a teacher at a government upper primary school in Kerala's Kasargod district, faced departmental action over a question he prepared on Savarkar in a 'freedom quiz' for school students at the sub-district level. The question was "who is the freedom fighter who received the most punishment at the hands of the British?".

The answer provided in the answer key was Veer Savarkar. The inquiry initiated against the teacher found that framing a question in a way that could spread a misleading impression was "very serious".

BJP state chief Rajeev Chan-

A TEACHER AT A GOVERNMENT SCHOOL FACED ACTION OVER A QUESTION HE PREPARED ON SAVARKAR IN A 'FREEDOM QUIZ' FOR STUDENTS

drasekar, however, claimed that punishing a teacher for preparing a quiz with 'historical facts' about Veer Savarkar was highly objectionable and demanded that his suspension be lifted. "It reveals a conspiracy to erase and rewrite the country's true history. The IJML is misusing power to punish teachers who teach historic facts. We have been saying all along that the government led by VJ Sathesan is held captive by the BJP," he alleged in a post on Facebook.

The BJP leader alleged that the government was hounding a teacher in a bid to placate extremist forces like Jamaat-e-Islami and the SDPI and practice

appeasement policies.

The BJP also carried out protests against the UDF government in Kasargod.

At the same time, state education minister N Shamsuddeen said that action against the teacher was taken on the basis of a report pointing to his guilt by the director general of education. "The inquiry will continue. If there are others who have had a role in this incident and who have attempted to impose their ideology and create issues in the education system, they will also face similar departmental inquiry," the minister said.

Asked whether the quiz had passed through Assistant Educational Officers (AEOs) and whether that indicated a lack of scrutiny by the Education Department, Shamsuddeen said it was a local programme conducted within the AEO jurisdiction every year. Meanwhile, BJP activists on Monday took out a protest rally at the venue in Kumbha where the minister was attending an inaugural event, opposing the suspension of the teacher over the controversial questionnaire, police said.

Enhanced security for AP land documents

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KALIDINDI: Andhra Pradesh chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday said the government was incorporating currency note-like security features into "tamper passbooks" (land documents).

Addressing a public meeting at Kalidindi in Eluru district as part of the "Mee Bhumi Mee Release" (My Land, Your Rights) programme, the CM said tamper-proof blockchain technology was being incorporated into the passbooks.

"We are implementing currency note-like security features in tamper passbooks. Through blockchain technology, we have ensured tamper-proof security to these assets," Naidu said, adding that QR codes and other security features had also been embedded.

"We are taking Naidu, more than 32 lakh patta passbooks have been distributed to farmers, while 9,365 villages were yet to undergo resurvey to enable the

distribution of another 69 lakh passbooks.

The CM said 41,000 acres of land had been removed from the 22-A list, paving the way for the distribution of patta passbooks to nearly 1.5 lakh farmers. In Eluru district alone, Naidu said, 500 acres of land had been removed from the 22-A list to facilitate the distribution of patta passbooks bearing the official seal.

Naidu said the government had begun digitising land records dating back to 1986, with all linked documents being brought online. Besides providing an auto-generation facility for nine lakh people, he said ancestral land valued at less than Rs 10 lakh could be transferred for a charge of just Rs 100.

Naidu asserted that the coalition government aimed to permanently resolve land disputes, which would help facilitate the release of land. He said the government had been sanctioned for Kalikuru to address drinking water issues in the Kolleru lake region, among other initiatives.

AR RAHMAN'S SON INJURED IN CAR ACCIDENT IN TN

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Son of Oscar-winning composer A.R. Rahman and playback singer A.R. Rahman suffered minor injuries after the luxury sports utility vehicle he was travelling in was involved in an accident with a cab-aggregator car early Monday, police said. According to police, the incident took place at around 3.30am on August 10 when Armaan was travelling towards Guindy with his friend in a black Porsche.

The cab-aggregator vehicle, which was moving on the left side of the road, entered the main lane, leading to the collision, police said. Police officials aware of the case said a case had been registered against the driver of the cab. After providing first aid, Armaan, his friend and the driver of the car were allowed to leave, police officials said. Both vehicles involved in the accident were towed away. Further investigation was being conducted based on surveillance camera recordings from the accident site, they said.

Resolution on state anthem passed unanimously in TN

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Assembly on Monday unanimously passed a resolution on the Tamil invocation song "Thamizh Thalai Vaazhthu" penned by the late poet, scholar Manonmaniam Sundaram Pillai, should be rendered at government functions.

"...Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu taken from the play 'Manonmaniam' written in 1891 by Manonmaniam Sundaram Pillai, must be sung first at government functions from November 23, 1970," the resolution stated.

The resolution was moved by chief minister C Joseph Vijay and was supported by the Opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), and other parties in the Assembly.

"Tamil is not just a language, but also a culture and a way of life. It is the identity of the people of Tamil Nadu. It is the right of every citizen to protect its language and culture. On the basis of that right,



TN CM C Joseph Vijay moves resolution mandating 'Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu' at the Legislative Assembly in Chennai on Monday.

shouldn't the Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu be given its rightful place?" Vijay said in his address.

Holding that Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu is a proud identity carrying all the greatness, he said, "a government order was passed requiring the song to be sung first at government functions starting November 23, 1970, and it was brought into force."

Observing that the song was recognised as the official state song on December 17, 2021, the chief minister said, "Government orders stipulate that Tamil

Thalai Vaazhthu must mandatorily be sung at events in all educational institutions, universities, government offices, public sector undertakings, and public organisations."

Vijay noted that soon after his government assumed office in May, he wrote a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi requesting appropriate recognition for the state song and procedures ensuring that Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu be sung first at state functions.

Underlining that the Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu is neither

against the Constitution nor against Indian unity, he said, "It expresses the noble Indian ideal of 'Unity in Diversity'."

Vijay appealed to all members of the Legislative Assembly to set aside party differences, unite and unanimously support this resolution being introduced to make the singing of Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu mandatory at the start of events across all educational institutions, universities, government offices, and public sector undertakings.

DMK MLA (Govt Chebriah) seconding the resolution, he supports the special resolution on behalf of the DMK.

He recalled that the DMK patriarch and former chief minister M Karunanidhi issued the very first government order on March 11, 1970, requiring the Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu song to be sung in government schools, universities, government offices and public sector undertakings. AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami said singing Tamil Thalai Vaazhthu is not an action against anyone, in fact it is the respect we pay in the Tamil Nadu's Janani Mantar.

"On behalf of the AIADMK, I wholeheartedly support this special resolution of the TVK

government," Palaniswami said. Congress, Indian Muslim League, and Viduthalaithiruvathal Katchi (VCK) which has a presence in Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay's cabinet, supported the resolution.

After hearing the comments from lawmakers from various parties, Speaker JCD Prabhakaran announced in the Assembly that the resolution had passed 'unanimously'.

Meanwhile, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) took pot shots at the Tamila Vetti Kazhagam asking what the need was for such a resolution.

"Nowhere has the central government or the Ministry of Home Minister's Office mentioned that the State song should be sung last. Resolutions cannot be made based on speculations," BJP spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathi told HT.

The move by the TVK government is in the backdrop of the advisory from the Union Home Affairs Ministry asking the states and union territories to "strictly comply" with its January 28 directive that the National Song Vande Mataram should be played before the National Anthem at official events.

TN steps up SIPCOT revival to turn industrial parks to job hubs

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NEW DELHI: Tamil Nadu has embarked on a revival mission of the industrial parks that were established under the State Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu (SIPCOT), minister S Keerthana said on Monday. In her address at the residences of Mathias and Shijin, the Tamil Nadu's industrial parks across the State evolve from being mere land banks into fully functional, investment ready industrial ecosystems capable of attracting investment, supporting manufacturing and creating employment.

The objective of the Revival Mission is to endow the industrial parks across the State with the necessary infrastructure and administrative constraints that prevent industrialisation. The objective of the Revival Mission is to endow the industrial parks across the State with the necessary infrastructure and administrative constraints that prevent industrialisation.



S Keerthana

ment, she said.

Under the leadership of the chief minister C Joseph Vijay, the SIPCOT Revival Mission would focus on removing bottlenecks on the ground and ensure that Tamil Nadu's industrial infrastructure keeps pace with its ambition to become a global competitive manufacturing and investment destination, she said.

During the discussion on the SIPCOT Industrial Park, Manaparai (located in Tiruchirappalli

district), the minister said, only on companies were in operation, even though land has been allotted for 32 factories.

"This gap between land allocation and actual industrial activity was a clear indication that investors were facing basic infrastructure and facilitation challenges that needed to be resolved on the ground," she said.

She attributed that the gap between the land allocation and actual industrial activity forced investors to face basic infrastructure and facilitation challenges that needed to be resolved on the ground. To boost the infrastructure at Manaparai, Keerthana said Rs 43.6 crore has been allocated by the SIPCOT for taking up infrastructure work in the new phase. An industrial park cannot be considered successful in when factories are being established, if people are getting jobs and if economic activity is taking place," she added.

Mohandas gets bail in remarks on protesters

Vishnu Varma

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A court in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday granted conditional bail to right-wing commentator TG Mohandas, a day after his arrest over allegedly provocative comments about people who took part in the recent protests in New Delhi's Janina Mantar.

He was taken into custody on Sunday and produced before the Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM) Court, where his counsel filed an application for bail.

The application was granted on the conditions that Mohandas not repeat such offences and cooperated with investigators.

In the remand report filed before the court, the police claimed that Mohandas had incited violence and that he had threatened to harm protesters. Investigators recovered digital evidence from his residence in



TG Mohandas

Matthancherry. They opposed bail on the grounds that more digital evidence needed to be collected and the owner of the YouTube channel on which Mohandas's alleged comments were aired was still absconding.

Lawyers aware of the prosecution's case against Mohandas said his age and health concerns to support the bail plea. The counsel also claimed that the allegations were politically motivated and police allegedly failed to issue him notice before he was detained.

TN govt sanctions ₹264 cr for anti-narcotics task force units

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu government on Monday said, it has accorded administrative sanction to establish anti-narcotics task force units at an outlay of ₹264.14 crore across the state. According to the government order dated August 8, a total of 65 Anti-Narcotics Task Force units to detect and take stringent action against drug-related crimes would be established in the state.

The force would comprise a staff strength of 65 inspectors, 130 sub-inspectors and 325 police personnel. The Anti-Narcotics Task Force would be established in 37 districts and 28 units allocated to police districts within nine city commission areas.

Chennai would have 12 units, two units each in Avadi, Tam-

A TOTAL OF 65 ANTI-NARCOTICS TASK FORCE UNITS TO DETECT AND TAKE ACTION AGAINST DRUG-RELATED CRIMES WOULD BE ESTABLISHED

baram, Salem, Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Tiruvallur, Madurai and Tirunelveli, the order said.

As per the order, the government accorded sanction for the creation of 65 police inspectors, 260 sub-inspectors and 1,300 police personnel for 65 Anti-Narcotics Task Force units on the basis of one inspector, 4 sub-inspector and 20 police personnel for each city commission area and personnel would not be used for any other police duties

except for the duties assigned to them, the order said.

The dedicated force would be headed by an Additional Director General of Police who would be assisted by one inspector general of police (operations), superintendent of police (intelligence) and administrative officer. A headquarters unit for the Anti Narcotics Task Force would be created with a strength of 454 posts and it would encompass 10 specialised internal units.

The Anti-Narcotics Task Force would engage in initiating legal actions on smuggling and sale of Narcotics drugs and abuse, collecting intelligence on the movement of narcotics and conducting cyber-surveillance operations. It would also register cases against the persons involved in criminal activities and investigating them.

Missing fisherman's kin criticise Sathesnan

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The family of one of the three fishermen, who have been missing at sea for the past 12 days, criticised chief minister VJ Sathesnan for the latter's remarks about the community and government inaction over the search operation.

John Mathias and Shijin, fishermen from Pulluvilla and Muthalappathi in Thiruvananthapuram district, and Gautam Krishna from Neendakara in Kollam district, have been missing at sea for the past 12 days after strong currents rocked their vessels during turbulent weather in separate incidents. Expert divers retrieved the bodies of Krishna's father and grandfather.

While CM Sathesnan visited the residence of Krishna and met his mother Reshma on Monday, home minister Ramesh Chinnappa and fisheries minister VE Abdul Gafoor paid visits to the residences of Mathias and Shijin. Mathias' children Jiji John and Nabin Nelson told the delegation of ministers that they raise strong objections to the remarks of Sathesnan. When asked about the search operations and alleged government apathy, "Is this the first time in Kerala's history that three people have gone missing at sea? Do you know how many people were missing during the LDF's 10-year rule? It was 148," Jiji said.

"If water is not released at Billigundlu now, the standing Kuruvai crop will wither before harvest, the ensuing Samba cultivation - the mainstay of the Delta, will equally be imperilled," the party has said.

flows into the Mettur reservoir for the Kuruvai paddy crop and preparations for the Samba crop.

The DMK, which approached the Supreme Court ahead of the Tamil Nadu government, has similarly sought immediate directions to Karnataka to release Cauvery water at Billigundlu and comply with the CWA's decision.

In its application, the DMK has described the present period as crucial for farmers in the Cauvery Delta, where the Kuruvai short-term paddy crop is raised and preparatory and transplantation operations for the Samba crop are undertaken.

"If water is not released at Billigundlu now, the standing Kuruvai crop will wither before harvest, the ensuing Samba cultivation - the mainstay of the Delta, will equally be imperilled," the party has said.

KTR alleges scam in PM Ekta Mall tenders, demands probe

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HYDERABAD: BRS Working President KTR Rama Rao (KTR) has alleged serious financial irregularities and a massive scam in the tender process for the proposed PM Ekta (Unity) Mall at Raidurg, Hyderabad, and demanded the immediate cancellation of the tender.

In a strongly worded letter to Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman, KTR urged the Centre to immediately stop further release of funds for the project and intervene before any irreversible decisions are taken.

He alleged that the Congress government in Telangana,



KTR Rama Rao

headed by chief minister Revanth Reddy, had framed questionable tender conditions that could result in disproportionate benefits to a private developer at the cost of public resources, according to a release.

Airline sources said the proposed project has an estimated cost of approximately Rs 2,059.81

crore, excluding the value of land, and has received around Rs 202 crore in central assistance. The project is proposed on approximately 6.30 acres of prime land at Raidurg, within 27 lakh square feet of built-up area.

The biggest concern, KTR said, relates to the distribution of commercial space. While the Government's central assistance in the project is only around 9 lakh square feet, the private developer is entitled to a minimum of 18 lakh square feet.

KTR questioned how a private developer could receive at least twice the Government's minimum built-up area in a project being developed on valuable public land with substantial Central financial assistance, the release said.

SC to hear TN's plea on Cauvery issue on August 13

S Vijay Karthik

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday heard Tamil Nadu's plea seeking directions to Karnataka to comply with the Cauvery Water Management Authority's (CWMA) decision to release 4,536 TMC of water per day for 15 days from the Kabin and Krishna Raja Sagara reservoirs.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant expressed to list the matter on Thursday after senior advocate CS Vaidyanathan, appearing for Tamil Nadu, made an urgent mentioning before him. The DMK's application seeking similar directions against Karnataka is also likely to come up for hearing on the same day.

Tamil Nadu has moved the Supreme Court alleging that Kar-

nataka has "wilfully" disobeyed the July 30 decision of the CWMA, which endorsed the recommendation of the Cauvery Water Regulatory Commission (CWRC) for the release of 3,500 cusecs per day for 15 days from July 29.

The state has sought directions to ensure that the mandated releases of 4,536 TMC of water per day - equivalent to 3,500 cusecs per day for 15 days, by August 12. But the state has claimed that this would still leave a substantial shortfall when the distress-sharing formula is applied. It has sought a direction to Karnataka to release an additional 26,954 TMC, which Tamil Nadu says represents

THE PLEA ALLEGED THAT KARNATAKA HAS 'WILFULLY' DISOBEYED JULY 30 DECISION, WHICH ENDORSED ORDER FOR THE RELEASE OF WATER

its pro-rata entitlement between June 12 and August 12. The state has alleged that Karnataka has not complied even with the limited 3,500-cusec direction.

According to the application, actual flows recorded at Billigundlu between July 29 and August 2 ranged from just 158 cusecs to 530 cusecs, substantially below the mandated daily release. It is evident that Karnataka has wilfully not complied with the direc-

tions of the CWRC/CWMA," Tamil Nadu has said.

The state has also relied on improved storage levels in Karnataka's reservoirs following recent rainfall to argue that there is sufficient water available to comply with the authority's direction.

As on August 3, Karnataka had gross storage of 7,537 TMC in its four principal reservoirs - 23,078 TMC in KRS, 18,610 TMC in Kabin, 7,827 TMC in Hanagudi and 28,022 TMC in Hemavathi, according to the application.

Tamil Nadu has sought directions to the CWMA to monitor Karnataka's reservoirs every 10 days and ensure compliance with the stipulated monthly and daily releases at Billigundlu.

The latest dispute comes at a critical point in the Cauvery irrigation calendar in Tamil Nadu with the Cauvery Delta dependent on

flows into the Mettur reservoir for the Kuruvai paddy crop and preparations for the Samba crop.

The DMK, which approached the Supreme Court ahead of the Tamil Nadu government, has similarly sought immediate directions to Karnataka to release Cauvery water at Billigundlu and comply with the CWA's decision.

In its application, the DMK has described the present period as crucial for farmers in the Cauvery Delta, where the Kuruvai short-term paddy crop is raised and preparatory and transplantation operations for the Samba crop are undertaken.

"If water is not released at Billigundlu now, the standing Kuruvai crop will wither before harvest, the ensuing Samba cultivation - the mainstay of the Delta, will equally be imperilled," the party has said.

The DMK has also pointed out that the 3,500-cusec release ordered by the CWMA for 15 days would amount to only about 4.5 TMC, substantially below Tamil Nadu's claimed entitlement even under the distress-sharing formula.

Tamil Nadu has told the Supreme Court that Karnataka's annual release obligation at Billigundlu under the Cauvery allocation framework aggregates to 12,334 TMC between June and January, comprising 12,334 TMC between June and September and 44.1 TMC between October and January.

An extra 10 TMC is earmarked towards environmental flows, taking the total annual requirement to 17,725 TMC. The state cited rainfall and inflow data to counter state's contention of water distress.

Stir at Kannur airport over AI Express delay

Press Trust of India

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KANNUR: Passengers protested and created a scene at the airport here on Monday morning after the rescheduling of an Air India Express flight from Kannur to Thiruvananthapuram, airline sources said.

Visuals aired on TV channels showed irate passengers shouting at airline personnel at the airport accusing them of not giving advance notification about the flight delay.

Airline sources said that a flight scheduled to arrive in the morning from Muscat got delayed as it was grounded there due to some technical reasons. The same flight was scheduled to depart to Thiruvananthapuram from there, they said.

"Therefore, the flight to Thiruvananthapuram got delayed. The flight from Muscat arrived subsequently and the flight to Thiruvananthapuram will leave shortly. The passengers were informed about the delay in advance. Those who protested at the airport were aware of the delay," an airline official said.

The flight to Thiruvananthapuram was scheduled to take off around 7 am but was delayed by several hours and will depart around 1 pm, the official said. The passengers were offered a refund or a rescheduling of their flight, he added. The official also claimed that no Air India Express flight to Dubai from Kannur was cancelled.

Must file FIR for every missing person, says SC

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed all states and Union territories (UTs) to immediately register first information reports (FIRs) whenever a person goes missing, irrespective of age or gender, expressing "shock" that some states were under the impression that its earlier direction applied only to missing children.

A bench of justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevkar termed the interpretation a "deliberate and mala fide bogey" and held that chief secretaries and directors general of police (DGPs) of states and UTs found to have failed to comply with its May 22 order would face contempt proceedings and be required to remain personally present before the court to explain the lapses.

"We are shocked to learn that some of the States are under the impression that the expression 'person' refers only to children and does not include adults. We find this to be a deliberate and mala fide bogey raised by such states," the bench said in its August 5 order, released on Monday.

Making it clear that there was no ambiguity in its earlier direction, the bench said: "The language of our earlier order is clear and unambiguous. The expression 'person' means every



The top court has warned of contempt notices, if any state or UT failed to comply.

person, irrespective of age or gender."

The court further directed that if any state or UT had failed to comply with the May 22 order "in its true letter and spirit", contempt notices should be issued to the concerned chief secretary and DGP. The two officers would have to remain personally present and file show-cause affidavits explaining why they should not be proceeded against and punished for their "deliberate defiance and non-compliance" with the court's orders.

The latest order came after the bench was informed that its May 22 direction required all states to register an FIR upon receiving information about any missing person. The court had, in that order, expressly directed every police station to immediately register an FIR the moment information was received about "any person missing", without waiting for a preliminary inquiry or asking the family to first search for the missing person.

The May 22 order had also left little room for such an interpretation: it specifically said that the FIR must incorporate the provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita relating to kidnapping, abduction or trafficking of a "person or child".

The Supreme Court's directions were issued as part of an ongoing exercise to put in place a coordinated, pan-India mechanism to deal with missing persons, human trafficking and the recovery and restoration of victims.

The court had emphasised that the first few hours after a person goes missing are the "golden hours" during which the chances of safe recovery are at their maximum. It therefore directed police not to wait for 24 hours before activating the machinery for tracing a missing person. Even where a person was traced and restored to the family within 24 hours, the police were required to act immediately.

The May 22 order had also directed that where police had sufficient reason to believe that a missing person case involved trafficking, it should be transferred to a specialised unit without waiting for the expiry of the four-month period. It further ordered the Centre and all states and UTs to make their anti-human trafficking units fully functional and operational within four weeks.

The court has now also found several states and UTs to be prima facie in contempt for failing to file affidavits despite its earlier directions. It directed contempt notices to the chief secretaries and DGPs of all states and UTs which had failed to file the required affidavits.

The court, meanwhile, recorded "substantial progress" in the wider exercise being undertaken by a committee headed by former Delhi high court judge Justice Mukta Gupta. Two zonal consultation meetings have already been held, with the third scheduled for August 8 and three more meetings proposed thereafter.

The committee was constituted to file frame a coordinated mechanism for tackling missing persons and human trafficking. The May 22 order had directed the Union home ministry to establish an all-India grid connecting every police station through a dedicated portal for human trafficking, including missing children and women, and integrate it with Mission Vatsalya and the Crime and Criminal Tracking Network System (CTNS).

The court on August 5 directed the Union government to communicate its concern to the concerned agencies over integration of the relevant portals and complete the exercise within six weeks. The matter will next be heard on October 5.

SC TO HEAR TN'S PLEA ON CAUVERY ISSUE ON AUG 13

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court will on Thursday hear Tamil Nadu's plea seeking directions to Karnataka to comply with the Cauvery Water Management Authority's (CWMA) decision to release 3,500 cuses of water per day for 15 days from the Kabin and Krishna Raja Sagar reservoirs.

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant agreed to list the matter on Thursday after senior advocate CS Vaidyanathan, appearing for Tamil Nadu, made an urgent mentioning before him.

The DMK's application seeking similar directions against Karnataka is also likely to come up for hearing on the same day.

Tamil Nadu has moved the Supreme Court alleging that Karnataka has "wilfully" disobeyed the July 30 decision of the CWMA, which endorsed the recommendation of the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) for the release of 3,500 cuses per day for 15 days from July 29. The state has sought directions to ensure that the mandated release reaches the inter-state border point at Billigundulu and that Karnataka also makes good the accumulated shortfall in releases.

The latest dispute comes at a critical point in the Cauvery irrigation calendar in Tamil Nadu, with the Cauvery Delta dependent on flows into the Mettur reservoir for the Kummavai paddy crop and preparations for the Samba crop.

Resolution on state anthem passed unanimously in TN

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Assembly on Monday unanimously passed a resolution that the Tamil invocation song "Thamizh Thai Vaazhin" penned by the late poet, scholar Manonmaniam Sundaram Pillai, should be rendered at government functions.

The resolution was moved by chief minister C Joseph Vijay and was supported by the Opposition Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), and other parties in the Assembly.

"Tamil is not just a language, but also our life and emotions. The Tamil Thai Vaazhin, upholds the diversity of entire India, must hold the primary place here in our Tamil Nadu. The Constitution of India itself grants every state the right to protect its language and culture. On the basis of that right, shouldn't the Tamil Thai Vaazhin be given its rightful place?" Vijay said in his address.

Observing that the song was recognised as the official state song on December 17, 2021, the chief minister said, "Government orders stipulate that Tamil Thai Vaazhin must mandatorily be sung at events in all educational institutions, universities, government offices, public sector undertakings, and public organisations."

Vijay appealed to all members of the Legislative Assembly to set aside party differences, unite and unanimously support this resolution. DMK MLA (Govi Chezhian) seconded the reso-



C Joseph Vijay

lution, said he supports the special resolution on behalf of the DMK. He recalled that the DMK patriarch and former chief minister M Karunanidhi issued the very first government order on March 11, 1970, requiring the Tamil Thai Vaazhin song to be sung in government schools, universities, government offices and public sector undertakings.

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami said singing Tamil Thai Vaazhin is not an action against anyone, in fact it is the respect we pay to the Tamil language. "On behalf of the AIADMK, I wholeheartedly support this special resolution of the TVK government," Palaniswami said.

The move comes in the backdrop of the advisory from the Union home ministry asking the states and Union territories to "strictly comply" with its January 28 directive that the National Song Vande Mataram be played before the National Anthem at official events.

4 suspended for ragging after junior doc found dead in Gujarat college

HT Correspondent

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AHMEDABAD: Four second-year MD Microbiology residents at the Government Medical College in Gujarat's Surat, were suspended for six months on Monday after an Anti-Ragging Committee found that they allegedly ragged junior doctors, a day after a first-year resident doctor was found dead in his room at the postgraduate hostel on the New Civil Hospital campus.

According to a government release, no suicide note was found, but statements of fellow students indicated that the deceased doctor had faced repeated mental harassment and torture by senior doctors.

Civil Hospital superintendent Dr Parul Vadgama said, the four suspended doctors, including three women, have been ordered to vacate the hostel and stay

away from academic activities for six months.

On Sunday, minister of state for health, Pratul Pansheriya, had ordered an investigation and asked for a report within 24 hours. College dean Dr Jayesh Brahmbhatt led the inquiry, which ran from 8.30 pm Sunday to 4 am Monday.

The committee questioned residents, senior doctors, hospital staff and Microbiology department faculty one by one.

"The Anti-Ragging Committee found that the conduct of the four doctors fell within the definition of ragging under National Medical Commission rules, involving verbal abuse, indecent behaviour and mental harassment," Vadgama said. No physical abuse was found, she added.

The hospital management will also file an FIR against the four doctors, superintendent Vadgama said.

EX-ARMYMAN KILLED IN HYD HIT-AND-RUN CASE

HYDERABAD: A 47-year-old ex-serviceman was killed, and two others were injured on Monday when a car allegedly driven by a drunk person on the wrong side of the road hit three two-wheelers at Hydrashakote, police said.

The incident occurred around 5.30 am when the car, allegedly driven at high speed in a rash and negligent manner, hit the three two-wheelers, killing the ex-serviceman on the spot and injuring two other riders, it said.

The deceased was identified as Ravinder, an ex-Subedar. Some residents informed the police about the accident.

The official said the car had four occupants, who abandoned the damaged vehicle and fled the spot. Based on credible information, police took all four occupants, including the driver, into custody, a police officer said.

The driver, who works as a delivery executive for a food delivery app, was subjected to a breathalyzer test, which came back positive, he said.

9 of MP family killed as van swept away in flooded drain



A crane lifted a van out of a flooded drain at Padana village in Rajgarh on Monday.

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BHOPAL: Nine members of a family, including four children, were killed after a van was swept away while crossing a flooded drain in Madhya Pradesh's Rajgarh district on Monday, police said, adding that two passengers were rescued by local residents. Chief minister Mohan Yadav announced a compensation of ₹4 lakh to the families of each of the deceased.

"...My condolences go out to

the bereaved families. Instructions have been issued to provide financial assistance," the CM said.

According to police, the incident took place in Padana town around 9 am when the Eco van was travelling from Dewas to Kadnabad village in Sarangpur tehsil for a religious visit. The victims were all residents of Satwala village in Dewas, while the two rescued men were admitted to Sarangpur hospital.

"As the vehicle reached the Padana bypass, water from the swollen Jhri drain had spilled over the road. Despite repeated warnings from locals, the driver tried to cross. The strong current 'swept the van into the drain,' said Anand Singh, sub-divisional officer of police (SDOP). Rescue teams from police, administration, and SDRF, along with villagers, launched operations using ropes and cranes. A witness, Mahendra Parmar said, "The water level was so high that the driver could not distinguish between the road and the drain. We urged him to

wait until the water receded, but he ignored the warnings."

Sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) Rohit Bamhare said, "A total of 11 people were involved: two of them were rescued. The bodies of nine people have been recovered; among the deceased...Two people were rescued by residents."

"Heavy rains had submerged the road, but despite warnings, the driver drove ahead, leading to the tragedy," he added. Meanwhile, high alert has been issued in 21 districts of MP.

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Amritpal's party fields Indira assassination convict's son for Pb polls

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AMRITSAR: Jailed Khador Sahib MP Amritpal Singh's party, Akali Dal (Ward Punjab De), on Monday named Satwant Singh — son of Kehar Singh, who was convicted of conspiracy in the assassination of former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi and subsequently hanged — as its first candidate for the Punjab assembly polls due early next year.

Satwant will make his electoral debut from the Bassi Pathana constituency in Fatehgarh Sahib district. The announcement was made during a joint press conference in Chandigarh by Tarsem Singh, WPD's acting president and Amritpal's father, and Faridkot MP Sarabjit Singh Khalsa.

Indira Gandhi was assassinated by her two bodyguards, Beant Singh and Satwant Singh, on October 31, 1984, to avenge Operation Blue Star. Kehar Singh was regarded as the mastermind of the assassination plot and hanged along with Satwant Singh in Tihar Jail on January 6, 1989.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, Beant's son Khalsa won the Faridkot seat as an independent while Amritpal Singh, founder of Akali Dal (WPD), won from Khador Sahib constituency, signalling a



Satwant Singh

resurgence of radical Panthic sentiment in Punjab politics.

Tarsem said the agenda of the party is not limited to seeking political power, but was focused on Panthic principles, Punjab's rights and recognising the contribution and dignity of families associated with sacrifices for the community. "Our recognition of such families is not confined to public statements," Tarsem said.

He added that family members of those who have made such sacrifices are also being given organisational responsibilities. As part of the organisational drive, the party has appointed Satwant's nephew Sukhwinder Singh Agwan to its parliamentary board, he added.

The party reaffirmed that its campaign for the 2027 state elections will remain focused on regional rights, Sikh political prisoners, and representation for prominent Panthic families.

KERALA TEACHER SUSPENDED OVER SAVARKAR QUIZ

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A school teacher on Sunday had been suspended over a question on right-wing ideologue VD Savarkar in a quiz, the BJP on Monday accused the Indian Union Muslim League of "misusing power to punish teachers who teach historical facts."

Guru Prasad, a government upper primary school teacher in Kasaragod, faced action over a quiz question asking: "who is the freedom fighter who received the most punishment at the hands of the British?". The answer key listed Veer Savarkar.

BJP state chief Rajeev Chandrasekhar alleged, "The UML is misusing power to punish teachers who teach historical facts."

Education minister N Shamsuddeen said the action was based on an inquiry report and that a probe is underway. **HTC**

Man kills daughters, attempts suicide at top B'loru hotel: Cops

Covercally Infresh
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BENGALURU: A 35-year-old man allegedly murdered his two daughters, aged five and 10, before attempting to die by suicide at a five-star hotel near Bengaluru's Kempegowda International Airport on Monday, police said.

Investigators said the girls were found dead inside a room at the hotel. The man, who was lying unconscious with severe throat injuries in the same room, was rushed to a private hospital, where his condition is stated to be critical, police said.

"We are also examining CCTV footage, digital evidence and other material collected. Once the accused is medically fit, his statement will be recorded," said deputy commissioner of police (DCP)

THE GIRLS WERE FOUND DEAD INSIDE A ROOM AT A HOTEL AND THE MAN WAS LYING IN THE SAME ROOM WITH SEVERE THROAT INJURIES

GK Mithun Kumar.

The premises are being examined by forensic personnel, who are expected to collect samples and other material that could help establish the sequence of events and determine the circumstances surrounding the incident.

"Further action will be taken based on the evidence," the deputy commissioner added.

The officer said that a note purportedly referring to a dispute over an alleged extramarital relationship was found in the room. However it has not been established if the alleged dispute was linked to the deaths.

"The contents of the note are being examined and we are verifying the allegations mentioned in it. At this stage, it would be premature to arrive at any conclusion regarding the motive," said Kumar.

Police said the man worked as a manager with a private firm. The room in question is on the fourth floor of the hotel.

Investigators said they were verifying the booking details and the bodies were sent to a mortuary for post-mortem examination to determine the exact cause of death.

{ U.P. CONVERSION CASE }

Pay ₹25L to women held captive: HC to govt, kin

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PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad High Court has ordered the Uttar Pradesh government and the father of two women, who were illegally confined at their parental home over their decision to convert from Hinduism to Islam, to jointly pay them ₹25 lakh compensation.

The court said that the women were free to reside at any place and with any person of their choice, without interference from their father or anyone else. It also told their father to hand them over their passports, educational certificates, identity documents, bank passbooks, cheque books, conversion-related documents and belongings within seven days.

Justice Sandeep Jain passed the order on August 6 while allowing a habeas corpus petition concerning Diya Bhatia alias Zoya Diya Bhatia (20) and Anshu Bhatia alias Armita Anshu Bhatia (35).

The women told the court they had voluntarily embraced Islam — Anshu in 2020 and Diya in 2021 — out of their own faith, conscience, mental peace and spiritual soke. They alleged their father subsequently confined them at their parental home against their wishes.

After interacting with the women, the court recorded that their responses were "spontaneous, coherent and unequivocal" and that nothing indicated either was acting under coercion, fear, inducement or undue influence.

HT

TG Mohandas gets bail over NEET stir remark
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A Thiruvananthapuram court on Monday granted conditional bail to right-wing commentator TG Mohandas, a day after he was arrested over provocative comments about Jantar Mantar protesters. The bail was granted on condition that he would not repeat such offence.

Sourav Ganguly gets threat letter
KOLKATA: Former India captain Sourav Ganguly and his family allegedly received threatening letters, following which his secretary lodged a complaint at Kolkata's Thakurpukur police station on Monday. The sender, identified as Arun from Belghoria, allegedly sent two letters threatening the former cricketer and his wife.

Study high-speed rail networks: Parl panel
NEW DELHI: The parliamentary standing committee on railways on Monday recommended a study of high-speed rail networks in nations where such systems operate efficiently. In the report tabled in Lok Sabha, the panel also suggested accelerated indigenisation of high-speed rail components and institutionalised capacity-building.

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SC seeks spl courts to hear Manipur violence cases

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday sought a report from the Manipur high court on feasibility of constituting two special courts to exclusively hear Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and National Investigation Agency (NIA) cases pertaining to the 2023 ethnic violence in the northeastern state after it was informed that 37 cases were ripe for trial.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Jyotsna Banerjee and V Mohana urged the chief justice of Manipur high court to consult all concerned stakeholders in this regard. It also directed the registrar general of the high court to file a status report on the issue before the next date of hearing.

"Considering the volume of witnesses and the fact that 899 witnesses remain to be examined, the Chief Justice of the Manipur high court in consultation with the concerned authority may consider the desirability of constituting two special courts—one for CBI and another for NIA," the bench noted in its order.

Earlier, the top court, which is monitoring investigation into cases arising from the ethnic violence in Manipur, had directed CBI to probe 31 cases and NIA 30



The court directed the state to extend full cooperation and assistance in the probe.

cases. Apart from the two federal agencies, special investigation teams (SITs) of Manipur Police are investigating 3,020 cases. Additional solicitor general (ASG) Ashwarya Bhatti, appearing for both CBI and NIA, informed the court that only five witnesses have been examined so far. The court was earlier informed that Manipur Police SITs have completed investigation in only 301 cases and trial has commenced in 11 of them. There are 2,924 witnesses to be examined and charges have been framed only in 31 cases.

The ethnic violence in Manipur broke out on May 3, 2023 between Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities. At least 260 people have been killed, several hundred injured and thousands displaced since then.

The top court also took note of the "sensitive" law and order situation in Manipur as submitted in a report by a committee

headed by former Maharashtra director general of police (DGP) Dattatraya Padsalgikar.

"We hope and trust that irrespective of the sensitive law and order situation, the SITs, CBI and NIA shall continue their ongoing investigation effectively," the bench said, directing the state to extend full cooperation and assistance to the investigating agencies.

Rehabilitation benefits delay
Meanwhile, the CJ-led bench also took note of the submissions of lawyers, including senior advocate Colin Gonsalves, that many affected Kuki-Zo families are yet to get the benefits of rehabilitation and welfare schemes.

The bench noted that details of their houses. More than 12,000 houses have so far been approved under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) for the affected families, the bench said.

The court asked the justice Gita Mittal committee to file a further report on the above grievances raised and also the challenges faced by the committee in getting their orders implemented.

1st Manipur govt-UNC talks 'fruitful, cordial'

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IMPHAL: The first round of talks between the Manipur government and the United Naga Council (UNC) to discuss the lifting of the ongoing economic blockade along national highways in the state was held on Monday, officials said, adding that the meeting discussed several agendas for restoration of peace in the hill state.

The talks were held at the Senapati district headquarters, where a delegation of ministers and nine MLAs, led by deputy chief minister L. Dibo and home minister Govindas Konhoujam, met with 12 UNC representatives, led by its president Ng Lorho.

Government spokesperson Thokchom Badheshyam described the meeting as an "ice breaker" and said further rounds of talks would be held.

"We had fruitful and cordial discussions. This is the first round of discussions, and a series of talks will follow to find a solution," he told reporters. The UNC charter of demands include arrests and justice for those involved in abduction of

six Liangmai Nagas, abrogation of suspension of operation (SOO) with Kuki militant groups among others.

However, the UNC president said the organisation would not lift its blockade until its four-point charter of demands was met. "We discussed with ministers and MLAs the way forward on how to bring peace. We discussed our four-point charter of demands, and we stick to it. Unless it is fulfilled, we will not end the blockade," Lorho told reporters.

Five houses set on fire
Meanwhile, five abandoned houses in a Kuki village in Manipur's Senapati district were set on fire by unknown miscreants on Monday, police said, adding that the identities of those involved are yet to be ascertained.

According to a senior police officer, who requested anonymity, "The village has been abandoned since 1992 Naga-Kuki conflict occurred over land issue. During that time around 8-10 households were displaced and later before 2023 the Kuki villagers resettled at the village."

SC permits Abhishek to travel abroad for surgery

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday asserted that every individual has a right to travel abroad and choose the medical treatment of their choice, as it pulled up the West Bengal government for opposing Trinamool Congress (TMC) lawmaker Abhishek Banerjee's request to travel overseas for an eye surgery.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Jyotsna Banerjee and V Mohana said it saw "no serious impediment" to Banerjee travelling abroad for three weeks for the treatment and allowed him to do so, subject to conditions aimed at ensuring his availability to the investigating agency.

"Every individual has a right to go abroad. Every individual has a right to choose the medical treatment of their choice," said the bench.

The Calcutta high court had earlier imposed a condition restraining him from travelling abroad without its permission while extending his interim protection from coercive action in the case.

The court also emphasised Banerjee's right to privacy in



Abhishek Banerjee

relation to his medical condition. "It is also a right to privacy to not bring your health records in public domain," it observed.

The state had opposed the plea, with additional solicitor general SP Raju submitting that there were at least 15 cases against Banerjee and arguing that his propensity to not return to India was now greater because criminal cases were pending against him.

The bench, however, questioned the nature of the allegations in the case in which the restriction on foreign travel had been imposed. "We are on to the nature of allegations. This is about a lecture given by him...there is no injunction against him in any other case," it observed. The court also pointed out that Banerjee had previously been permitted to travel abroad in matters involving more serious allegations.

FIR AGAINST ARMY MAJOR, 15 JAWANS FOR ASSAULTING COP, HOME GUARD

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DEHRADUN: Uttarakhand police have booked an alleged army major and 15 unidentified defence personnel for assaulting a home guard volunteer and a constable over an alleged tiff resulting from a traffic check in Chamoli district, officers said.

Chamoli SP Surjeet Singh Panwar said, "We have registered an FIR in the matter, and the investigation is underway."

LI Col Chetan Singh Kabsuri, defence PIO Dehradun, said, "We have learnt about the incident through newspapers. The investigation is underway."

According to the complaint filed by constable Vijay Singh, one of the victims, the incident allegedly took place on August 8 when home guard Dinesh Singh was managing traffic near Mana bridge and saw an army gypsy.

Dinesh alleged that the man in civilian clothes was sitting with a driver inside the gyps and identified himself as Major Anmol Preet. Soon, the man became enraged over being stuck in traffic for a long time. People aware of the matter said that the accused major was posted in the 64 Assault Engineer Regiment.

12 injured in firing along Arunachal-Assam border

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SILCHAR: 12 Assam villagers were allegedly injured, three critically, in firing by unidentified people along the interstate border with Arunachal Pradesh on Monday, police said.

The two states share over 800 km of border, parts of which are disputed and the source of localised clashes, triggered by allegations and counter-allegations over land encroachment.

Police said they are investigating the incident and have deployed a large force to prevent the situation from escalating.

The incident happened at Mingmang Badati area under the Gogamukh Revenue Circle of Dhemajai district along the Assam-Arunachal border on Monday morning.

"A group of armed men in uniform came towards us and started saying that they will take their land anyhow. Before we could say anything, they started firing," said an injured person, adding that 18 locals were working in that area and eight or nine escaped unharm.

The injured were identified as Durgeshwar Patir, Rohit Doley, Nagun Doley, Bigneshwar Patir, Pame Pegu, Sanjay Tayung, Uptal Doley, and Jan Doley, all residents of Mingmang Badati area. The identities of the other four are yet to be ascertained, police said.

All eight injured persons were initially taken to the Gogamukh Rural Hospital. Seven, with three in critical condition, were moved to the Dhemajai civil hospital. They were later referred to the Assam



Heavy security deployed in Dhemajai district.

Medical College and Hospital (AMCH) in Dibrugarh for specialised care.

Mingmang Badati locals alleged regular attempts by border residents from Arunachal Pradesh to encroach on land in Assam. "From their side, not only common people but senior police officers also came to encroach our land and the officers in uniform fired on us," said an injured person.

Assam police, however, said these claims have not been verified and are investigating the matter. "We are investigating, we'll also have a talk with officials of Arunachal Pradesh police," an investigating officer told the media on Monday afternoon.

Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said that he is aware of the incident and the director general of police (DGP) and other senior officials to intervene and investigate. "I have instructed the DGP, Chief Secretary and other officials to look into it and they'll also talk to their counterparts in Arunachal Pradesh. But I think it is a local land dispute issue and not a matter of two states, we are in a peaceful situation," he said.

AUTOMATIC COVERS MUST FOR TIPPERS, DUMPERS FROM APRIL 2027: GOVT

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NEW DELHI: All tippers and dumpers will need automatic covers from April 1 next year to fully enclose the load body while operating on the road, according to new rules notified by the Union ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH).

The requirement is aimed at ensuring that the load body remains fully enclosed while the vehicle is moving on the road.

The Central Motor Vehicles (Twelfth Amendment) Rules, 2026, notified on July 28 and published in the Gazette of India on August 7, require all dumpers and tippers to have an electrically, electro-mechanically, hydraulically or mechanically operated system to cover the load body from the top. The system can use any suitable material for the cover.

"In case of all dumpers and tippers, the load body shall be fitted with an electrically or electro-mechanical or hydraulic or mechanically operated system to cover the load body from top to fully enclose the load body while the vehicle is moving on the road."

The new rules also require an audio-visual alert to be in the driver's cabin.

The system must warn the driver if the load body cover is open or unsecured during the vehicle's movement.

The government also said that the equipment used to enclose the load body will not be counted when measuring the vehicle's overall height.

ATTARI, MOREH AMONG 11 PORTS ADDED FOR E-VISA ENTRY AND EXIT

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NEW DELHI: The Centre on Monday notified 11 additional ports, including Attari on India-Pakistan border and border town of Moreh in Manipur, for facilitating entry into and exit from India for the foreigners holding electronic visa (e-visa), according to a statement issued by the Union home ministry.

With the latest addition, the total number of international ports enabling entry of foreigners holding E-visa has increased to 88, including 37 airports, 38 seaports and 13 land ports.

The move brings airports, seaports, land borders and rail ports under a common framework defined by the new Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025. The newly added international ports are Attari in Punjab (through road), Moreh in Manipur, Dawki in Meghalaya, Dawki, Jaigaon, Haridaspur, Gede and Ghojand in West Bengal, Darranga in Assam and Agartha.

"The government of India has notified 11 more International Ports, enabling E-visa holder foreigners to enter India. The newly added 11 International Ports include nine land ports and two airports. The addition of 11 International Ports further enhances the attractiveness and utility of electronic Visas," the MHA said in a statement.

Notably, India provides approximately 55% e-visa applications in less than 72 hours the ministry added.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

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'SHAH TO REPLY IN PARLI'

them." Both the Congress and the SP said debates on both issues were non-negotiable.

"The question was never that Amit Shah would come and speak on some general topic. Neither we nor the nation is interested in his view on education. We are not interested in any fantasy statements from Shah. He has to clarify who authorised the shooting at the youngsters in Delhi. Students were fired at. They were beaten with lathi with nails. Shah is guilty of either negligence of culpability and he must resign," Gandhi said.

Over the past two weeks, the ongoing monsoon session has been largely washed out because the Opposition demanded a statement from Shah in the House over allegations of police excesses and the use of pellet guns at the July 20 protest demanding the resignation of then education minister Dhanendra Pradhan.

To be sure, the supplementary list of business started earlier in the day that Shah was going to introduce two bills - one to formally change the name of Kerala to Keralam, and another to amend the National Co-operative Development Corporation Act. Eventually, the first bill was introduced by Union Minister of state (MoS) Nityanand Rai and the second by MoS Murlidhar Mohol.

For the SP, which faces the Uttar Pradesh assembly elections scheduled early next year, the controversy around Ram Mandir collections has been the top issue in the monsoon session, which ends on August 13.

"The Opposition have been demanding from the very first day that the home minister make a statement. The government is not ready to do so. There are still two days left, and the government has time to discuss both issues. It is not an ordinary matter that the offerings made to Lord Ram have been stolen. The faith of crores of people has been hurt. People who donated money, offerings and dakshina with faith and devotion, were government or BJP leaders involved in it? Who will ultimately answer for this?" SP chief Akhilesh Yadav said.

Yadav alleged that the BJP formed governments by playing with people's faith and devotion. "Why does the government not want a discussion on this issue? And the second issue is the lathi-charge on young people and the way the children, youth and students were humiliated. They were not only NEET aspirants. Along with NEET students, all those who appeared for examinations across

the country and in Uttar Pradesh, including those who could not take their exams because of paper leaks, were present there."

Hours later, Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and Gandhi said that Shah's statement on police excesses and Ram Mandir theft were non-negotiable for the party.

Kharge and Gandhi both said the Opposition's first demand was the home minister's statement on allegations of police overreach, including the use of pellet guns and shock batons on July 20. The second demand was that the prime minister reveal the truth about the 'offering theft' and take the strictest possible action against the culprits. The two leaders said that the third demand was apologies from the PM and home minister.

Kharge argued that for two weeks, the government didn't agree to a debate on students. "This means that Shah didn't want the debate. The PM played a big role in setting up Ram Mandir trust. He picked members who were close to him. But when people raised questions on theft and Modi's trusted trustee—he didn't reply. We wanted the PM to apologise to the nation because millions of people have faith in Ayodhya. Both the PM and HM are silent on these issues, which are non-negotiable. These are non-negotiable issues," Kharge said.

Gandhi alleged that people close to the PM stole from the Ram Mandir collections and criticised Shah and Narendra Modi for not coming to the House for the past 15 days. According to a senior non-Congress MP, the presser was an attempt to avoid any fissures in the Opposition camp.

Congress general secretary KC Venugopal has written to Birla to urge him to demand Shah's statement on the police brutalities on students on the floor of the House. Hours later, Union minister JP Nadra accused Gandhi of deliberately disrupting Parliament for the last 15 days and misleading the country. "Gandhi was demanding a statement from home minister Amit Shah on the Jantar Mantar protest. When the home minister agreed to his demand, the Congress leader changed his goalpost and started demanding a discussion on the alleged embezzlement of Ram temple donation," Nadra said. "Why are they running away from the discussion? I want to state clearly: Rahul Gandhi, do not run away from the discussion. We are ready. We are prepared to discuss every issue inside the House. Do not run away," he added.

DELHI RAIN

The normal of 34.2°C.

The average maximum temperatures in June, July, and August so far have remained close to the IMD's monthly LPAs. June saw a mean maximum temperature of 39.2°C, only 0.2°C above the climatological mean, while July's mean maximum temperature was recorded at 35.5°C, only 0.1°C below the climatological mean. The average maximum temperature for August so far is 33.1°C, while the climatological mean is 34.2°C.

It has been a wetter-than-normal monsoon for Delhi from June 1 to August 10, with 534.3mm of showers.

Delhi received 258mm rain in July against an average of 209.7mm. June received a deficit with 41.8mm rain, against an average of 74.1mm.

This comes even as India continues to grapple with a bruising El Niño that threatens to choke the rest of the monsoon. The weather system, characterised by a warming of the waters of the eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean, drove ocean temperatures to a new record this July. The average sea surface temperature reached 20.8°C last month, against the July 2023 record of 20.89°C.

To be sure, the showers have largely been concentrated over a few days.

Satellite recorded 224.7mm between August 4 and 8, the rainiest five days this season and the most rain Delhi has recorded within five days in August for at least 15 years. Last year, the city recorded only 144mm between August 1 and 10.

In the last 15 years, Delhi's August rain has crossed the LPA only five times - in 2025, 2024, 2020, 2013, and 2012.

With IMD forecasting more rain in the coming week, experts said the city is likely to end the month well in excess.

"More rains are expected in the next 24 hours, which could add around 50mm to 80 mm to the current figure, while rainfall during the entire week may raise the number to 100mm. Tomorrow we are predicting strong rain across Delhi NCR, which will not be as severe as last Friday, but during the afternoon and evening, there are chances in some areas of a downpour which causes waterlogging," said Navdeep Dahiya, an amateur meteorologist.

Monday's rain, largely concentrated in south and east Delhi, pushed the city into a fresh cycle of snarls.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

IMD has issued a yellow alert for light to moderate rain on Tuesday, predicting a few spells of very light to light rain at most places with moderate rain at a few places during early morning to noon, while another spell of very light to light rain is expected towards the evening or night.

IMD categorised rainfall up to 15.5mm as light, 15.6-64.4mm as moderate, 64.5-115.5mm as heavy and 115.6-204.4mm as very heavy.

Despite the showers, the city's Air Quality Index (AQI) has remained in the "satisfactory" category since the start of the month.

On Monday, the Central Pollution Control Board recorded the daily average AQI at 89.

"There will be certain hours during which the AQI dips into the 'good' category, but largely the average will remain in the 'satisfactory' category because during the hours when it is not raining and the wind speed is also not high, the AQI increases," Dahiya said. The lowest AQI average this month, 63, was recorded on Friday and Saturday.

J'KHANDI PROTEST

I. Khanting on charges of corruption and questioned former JPS member Ajita Bhattacharya. On July 22, CID registered a first information report against JPS officials and TDJ — the private agency which conducted the exam — for widespread manipulation and rigging in state competitive examinations.

On Sunday, after talks between the students and the government, J'Khanda had cancelled three JPS exams — the 14th JPS Combined Civil Services Preliminary, the JPS Combined Civil Services Backlog Examination 2023, and the JPS Combined Civil Services Backlog Examination 2025. All three JPS members — Ajita Bhattacharya, Anima Hansda and Jamal Ahmad — resigned.

Students vowed to continue their agitation.

"Is this Pakistan, Bangladesh, or the China border? These are students. Why does the government want anarchy instead of just agreeing to the students' rightful demands?" asked student leader Devendra Nath Mahto, who has been on a hunger strike for nine days. The government struck a conciliatory tone.

"You have raised your voice for your demands in a peaceful manner. In a democracy, it is your right to express your views,

and it is the government's responsibility to respect your voice. The government has heard you. Our senior ministers have been in constant dialogue with you, and I assure you that action will be taken on your demands with utmost seriousness and sensitivity," chief minister Hemant Soren said on X, blaming the Opposition for the ruckus.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi — whose party is part of the alliance ruling J'Khanda — criticised the violence.

"The use of force against students protesting in J'Khanda is wrong. Students have a right to peaceful protest, and only dialogue can yield solutions. The J'Khanda government must continue to hear these students out and resolve their issues immediately," he posted on X.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) attacked Gandhi. "Barbed wires have been put up in J'Khanda at the behest of Rahul Gandhi and the government, of which they are a part. Can he not hear the voices of the students there? The kind of double standards Rahul Gandhi and the Congress party are adopting, they are working to create anarchy, bring negative politics, and play the role of an irresponsible Opposition, thereby harming the future of the country and preventing the country from progressing properly," Union Minister JP Nadra said.

The sit began on July 25 over allegations of corruption and irregularities in the 14th JPS exam. In the shadow of a larger protest in Delhi's Jantar Mantar that eventually led to the resignation of the Union education minister.

The protesters have raised five core demands. These include the cancellation of the disputed exams, an independent central investigation into the irregularities, systematic recruitment and calendar reforms, ban on private testing agencies, and strict legal penalties.

The protesters have said that the government has yet to fulfil the demand of cancelling the JSSC CGL exam and a CBI probe into the irregularities. On Monday, the march began at 10.40am as thousands of people from different parts of the state held the national flag and walked to the new state assembly building, defying administrative orders and breaking barricades along the way.

Police resorted to lathi charge late in the evening to disperse protesters at Gate No.1 of the state assembly, where discussions on the budget ended at 2.30pm — about an hour before the agitators reached the premises.

"Eighty percent of the agitators marched peacefully but 15 to 20 percent created a law and order problem, compelling the police to take action. While three policemen sustained injuries four students also sustained injuries. In the clash during the march, as the place where students were agitating in the evening is a secluded place, police used a mild lathi charge to disperse the agitators from there," Ranchi superintendent of police (SP) Paras Rana said.

"The baton charge was barbaric. We were protesting peacefully, but the government used batons against us. They can only inflict physical injuries, not harm our thoughts," protester Piyush Kumar Soni was quoted as saying by news agency PTI.

Protesters broke seven barbed barricades despite the presence of around 1,500 police personnel. "Police did not disturb the students' march after the session ended and all legislators left the assembly premises. Police personnel allowed them to move to Gate No. 1, which is for the entrance of VIPs," a police officer said.

"Whatever the Hemant Soren government is doing to us is not good. We were protesting peacefully, then why is your police baton charging at us?" protester Vikram Kumar told PTI.

Around 2pm, tensions flared near Jagannathpur temple. "Students threw shoes and stones at the police. In response, the police fired back-to-back rounds of tear gas and used water cannons to disperse the volatile crowds. Lathi was also used. A policeman and a student sustained injuries in the clash," a policeman said on the condition of anonymity.

Mahto arrived at the protest site on a palanquin. "When the government put up spiked barricading, despite not being well, I could not stop myself," he said. Mahto was admitted to a hospital in Ranchi as his health deteriorated. "He is being treated in the emergency ward," Nancy Priya, Medical Officer at Ranchi Sadar Hospital was quoted as saying by PTI.

JPS-JSSC Reforms March spokesperson Piyush Kumar Singh said the students will continue their protest. Akhil Bharatiya Vidhyarthi Parishad (ABVP) said it will gear up the assembly on Tuesday.

Glitches cited in AI incident; Airbus to assist in AAIB probe

Neha LM Tripathi

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NEW DELHI: Airbus on Monday said it was sending specialists to assist an investigation into the sudden altitude loss of an Air India A320neo aircraft last week, even as people familiar with the matter cited a preliminary defect report (PDR) prepared by the pilots to suggest that the incident was preceded by multiple technical glitches, including an autopilot disconnection.

With the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) commencing its probe into the August 4 incident, teams from the French agency, Bureau of Enquiry and Analysis for Civil Aviation Safety (BEA), as well as the aircraft's manufacturer Airbus will assist in the probe, as per the standard operating procedures.

The Phuket-Delhi flight AI2739 experienced a sudden loss of altitude of around 300 feet during cruise, causing injuries to 13 passengers and four crew members. An initial statement from Air India had cited turbulence as the reason.

Soon after the incident, the aircraft, with 137 passengers and eight crew members on board, stabilised and landed safely in Delhi. The pilots of the flight have been off-rostered pending probe. The pilot-in-command's (PIC) preliminary drug test returned "non-negative," a government release said. The results of a confirmatory second test is awaited.

Two persons aware of the matter said the pilots had mentioned technical issues with the aircraft in the PDR. "The PDR mentioned that the autopilot disconnected. It also mentioned a stall warning and a light control ECAM (Electronic Centralised Aircraft Monitor) message," said one of these persons, requesting anonymity.

Sam Thomas, president of Airline Pilots' Association of India (AIPA India), said the first officer took control of the situation, citing papers filed by the airline with the aviation regulator.

"The pilots have followed the rule book while cruising. They declared PAN PAN so that medical help is received as soon as they land. The aircraft's technical glitches were handled well and within time by the first officer while the PIC was not on his seat. MAY DAY call was not necessary as the systems had recovered," Thomas said.

A second official said the matter "is being investigated considering all the angles including suspected technical glitch."

The incident, which the civil aviation ministry classified as serious, is being investigated by the AAIB as per Annexure 13 of the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO).

"In accordance with ICAO Annex 13, Airbus is providing technical assistance to the relevant investigating authorities. We are actively supporting the airline and will provide further information as it becomes available. A team of specialists is being dispatched to assist with the investigation," an Airbus spokesperson said. The Airbus team is likely to arrive in Delhi on Tuesday night.

Air India had reportedly written to Airbus about the technical issues. The airline's spokesperson did not comment on the development citing ongoing probe. "As the investigative process is ongoing, Air India cannot comment on any findings or observations related to the investigation. We will continue to extend our full cooperation to relevant authorities as required," the spokesperson said.

Bharti is A&N chief secy

NEW DELHI: Senior IAS officer Gyanesh Bharti has been appointed as the new Chief Secretary of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, according to an order from the Union Home Ministry.

Bharti was serving as the deputy election commissioner. The 1998-batch IAS officer of

AGMUT cadre was repatriated to his parent cadre by the order of the appointments committee of the cabinet on the request of the Union home ministry, a government order said. The home ministry appointed Bharti as the new Chief Secretary of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

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Hindustan Times

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{ OUR TAKE }

Monumental neglect in Delhi

The encroachment of four Lodhi-era tombs shows while history holds pride of place in the country, not enough is done to protect heritage

To the earth-worn, suffering man, Rome is the city of visible history, where the past of the whole world seems moving in funeral procession with strange ancestral images and trophies gathered from afar." George Eliot could have easily written the above about Delhi. A capital for many regimes in history, Delhi is a city of monuments, each a trophy of its era. It is also a city of migrants, each wave adding its colour to the city's landscape — some living in posh bungalows and upscale colonies and others cheek by jowl in tenements that dot urban villages.

It is in the jostling between these two populations — one inert (the city's monuments) and the other human — that Delhi grows and groans. HT reported on August 10 on how encroachment at varying scales, squalor, and official apathy have come together to swallow four Lodhi-era tombs in Zamrudpur in southern Delhi. All four are recognised by the Delhi government as top-tier heritage buildings, which come with a long list of protections — at least on paper. Unplanned housing abutting their walls, usage of space as cattle-shed, and integration of one tomb's structure into the construction of a tenement, however, undermined how official mandates are crushed by everyday apathy.

Of course, this is not the only instance of encroachment on heritage monuments in the Capital — the protracted litigation over the unauthorised taking over of a Lodhi-era monument in Defence Colony is just one example of how such behaviour is not limited to one geography or class. Sketchy definitions, lax regulation, and limited implementation have enabled such practices.

For a country where history holds such pride of place in the national consciousness, not enough attention is given to actually protecting this heritage. This must change.

In Gaza, a Sisyphean situation for the world

Even if Hamas were disarmed, will Israel withdraw from Gaza? It seems like such a foregone conclusion that the very question appears to be moot. Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu has, as expected by many, discarded the 15-point Gaza peace programme negotiated by the US. "They have ideas, some of which are acceptable to us and some are not acceptable to us," he said on August 9.

What has been rejected by Netanyahu is US President Donald Trump's "peace" project, announced as a "historic agreement" on July 30, and achieved after almost six months of negotiations by the US-led Board of Peace, consisting of nearly 40 countries. While Netanyahu's rejection of any prospect of peace involving curbs on Israel's unilaterally decided military action in the region could have been predicted with some certainty, Trump's response is where the chips are stacking.

Initially backing Israel unequivocally, even at the cost of adverse reactions from his voter base, Trump has begun to express dissatisfaction with Netanyahu's attitudes. While Trump seems to be in a hurry to get out of military meddling in West Asia, Netanyahu seems to want the region to simmer. The allies seem to be at loggerheads as they have contrasting domestic goals tied to the situation. Trump is beginning to worry about his dipping approval ratings, significantly owing to inflation, a ripple-effect of war-disrupted supply chains, as the November mid-term polls inch closer. Netanyahu, on the other hand, seems to have consolidated his position through his relentless attacks on Gaza and Lebanon, along with sporadic military action against other countries in the region, citing Israel's right to defend itself.

Despite Netanyahu's rejection, Hamas has declared its commitment to the plan. However, the ball remains firmly in Israel's court as no degree of disarmament undertaken by the Palestinian political group may be enough to convince Israel. The boulder can roll down right after reaching the summit. What comes out of this Sisyphean situation in West Asia will continue to have implications for the rest of the world.

Challenges India faces from the Mecca pact

It embeds Pakistan in West Asia's growing, evolving security architecture, even as the region has become a battleground for India-Pakistan competition

There was always something inevitable about the new Pakistan-Saudi Arabia-Turkey mutual defence agreement. Islamabad's security ties with longtime allies Riyadh and Ankara have intensified in recent years, culminating in last year's Pakistan-Saudi Arabia defence pact and stepped-up Pakistan-Turkey defence cooperation that resulted in Pakistan drawing on Turkish drones in its conflict with India last year. And after many years of tensions, Ankara and Riyadh have experienced a rapid rapprochement — one spearheaded by 2023 Turkish drone deals. With the three countries further increasing cooperation during the Iran war, recent months had produced ample buzz about an imminent new trilateral arrangement.

With each country having a strong interest in deterring Iran and Israel, there was an urgent imperative to band together. And with each country bringing something unique to the table — Pakistan's nuclear capacities, Saudi Arabia's oil money and wider capital, and Turkey's arms production — comparative advantage was

never going to be a problem. But it's also important not to overlook how the Donald Trump factor gave the three countries such a strong rationale to conclude a deal, as well.

The Mecca agreement has likely been received well by the White House. The Trump administration wants to see more burden-sharing by its allies in ways that help advance US interests. The pact — a collective effort at deterrence, with an eye toward Tehran — does exactly that.

That positive response in Washington is what the signatories want, given that each is keen to ensure continued strong ties with the Trump administration. To that end, public messaging about the deal from the three signatories has been smart. It has emphasised that the pact is not meant to target any particular country. This is likely meant to prevent any US concern about the pact being used against Israel for offensive or other hostile purposes.

But there's an irony here: While the deal may be acceptable to Washington, it was pursued in great part because of concerns about Washington. It's unlikely that any of the signatories that the US's own deterrence capacities can no longer be counted upon in West Asia: Washington has been unable to deter Iran, and it is unwilling to deter Israel. It's also a case of hedging against the unpredictability of the Trump administration: With no clear indication of what its approach will

be to Israel, Iran, or the wider region in the coming months, the three countries decided to take matters into their own hands.

Earlier this year at Davos, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney called on the world's middle powers to unite amid global chaos and push back against superpowers — including the US. He warned that "if we're not at the table, we're on the menu." The Mecca deal is a case of three key regional players taking a seat at a table where they believe the US no longer sits.

To be sure, the US remains a formidable actor in West Asia. And to its credit, it has pushed for peace in Iran. Also, US Vice President JD Vance has castigated Israel for its military policies — highly rare US criticism of its close ally. But at the end of the day, Iran — through its own actions and those of its proxies — continues to threaten the region, and Israel continues to strike Gaza. And with the US having reduced its envoy dependence on West Asia and the Trump administration having asserted that its most serious security and strategic threats are closer to home, it's quite likely the US will become less present in the region whenever the war ends in fact.

For India, these hedging tactics are quite familiar. From accelerating an ongoing modest rapprochement with China to pushing to finalise a new FTA with the EU, New Delhi has done its own share of hedging activities against US unpredictability to



The pact reflects a view that the US's deterrence capacities can't be counted upon: It has been unable to deter Iran, and is unwilling to deter Israel. AP

advance its interests. And on one level, the Mecca deal could help India as well. India stands to benefit from any stability the pact helps create. India is a big part of West Asia's evolving geo-economic architecture, from the I2U2 Quad to IMEC. India also has deep ties with Israel, the world's fastest-growing major economy, and is an attractive investment space — all major advantages in today's West Asia. And, incidentally, none of which apply to Pakistan.

But the Mecca deal also presents new challenges for India. It institutionalises security partnership between Pakistan and Turkey — one an Indian rival, the other a country with shaky ties with New Delhi — and Saudi Arabia, one of India's closest partners in West Asia.

Second, it further embeds Pakistan in West Asia's growing, evolving security architecture. This is significant, because the region has become a battleground for India-Pakistan

competition. India and Pakistan view West Asia as a highly strategically significant space for the same reason: It is home to many of their closest partners, to the majority of their hydrocarbon imports, and to large expatriate communities. Both countries are active there, and the Mecca deal — at least for now — puts India on the back foot.

Ultimately, however, the main takeaway from the deal is that it reflects the willingness of global players to go their own way and form new arrangements to hedge against the Trump administration's unpredictability. Such efforts bolster the causes of multilateralism and multipolarity — outcomes that will be welcomed in New Delhi, even if several key actors involved aren't on its friend list.

Michael Kugelman is resident senior fellow for South Asia at the Atlantic Council in Washington, DC. The views are personal.

Tapping defence human capital for education

The education sector presents an excellent opportunity for the Armed Forces to contribute skilled manpower to the Videsh Bharati initiative, which seeks to make India a repository of human capital by 2047. Apart from the National Education Policy (NEP 2020) initiative to hire professors of practice from among distinguished veterans of the armed forces with academic pedigree, there is little else that leverages the vast potential of thousands of retiring servicemen and women in the education sector. Given the current turbulence in the education space and the government's inclination towards further reform, this article suggests methodologies to leverage the multiple competencies of Armed Forces personnel in the education sector.

While attempts have been made by the services and the government to ensure that servicemen and women who retire every year are integrated into civil society and take up a second career, much can still be done to leverage the wide range of competencies of these disciplined citizens could offer the country in the process of nation-building. Leveraging the multiple competencies of men and women who have served the nation with selfless commitment in the education sector offers scope for immense value addition.

The sheer diversity and range of competencies and educational qualifications possessed by retiring personnel must be carefully examined by the ministry of education and matched to suitable institutions and initiatives. As compared to earlier times, when most of the Personnel Below Officers Rank (PBORs) retired without a graduate degree, the situation has changed significantly today. Large numbers of PBORs, particularly from the navy and air force, acquire degrees during service through correspondence courses, while those from the Army Education Corps (AEC) may have had the opportunity to acquire graduate degrees while in service. These PBORs have excellent potential to teach in rural schools, especially in regions where they hail.

Army PBORs from the Corps of Signals, Corps of Engineers and Corps of Electrical and Mechanical Engineers (EME), and technically proficient air force and naval PBORs, who have actively worked on ships, aircraft and systems, have excellent potential to teach in vocational training institutes and ITIs, in a regional language, Hindi, or English, depending on their abilities. As far as the navy and air force are concerned, a small percentage of PBORs even acquire a post-graduate degree and are capable of being trained and absorbed at the college level and, in a few cases, even at the university level. Of interest to the education sector should be those PBORs from all three services who have instructional experience at various training establishments with certification and potential to teach at vocational training institutes. The education ministry needs to curate customised teaching and instructional pedagogy courses for such personnel to familiarise them with existing teaching methodologies.

Most officers in the three services superannuate between the ages of 54-56. A growing number are seeking premature retire-

ment (PR) between the ages of 40-50, and a few opt for PR even earlier due to compelling personal reasons. Many of these officers are post-graduates with varied competencies cutting across disciplines. Several of these officers have teaching and instructional experience in various institutions of professional learning, a comprehensive list of which can be obtained from the service HQs. While the corporate sector has welcomed retiring officers with open arms, the same cannot be said of the education sector, mainly because of poor pay scales and a lack of institutionalised government initiatives beyond the professor of practice initiative.

Several PBORs retire and settle down in their native villages/towns, taking up jobs in the unorganised sector or looking after their ancestral property. With those graduate degrees can easily be motivated to become school teachers after specialised training that need not necessarily be a B.Ed. Some of the PBORs with a technical background can join vocational institutes, with more permutations and combinations. If the right strategy is adopted, moving up the value chain, officers with the requisite qualifications can easily join colleges, ITIs, and other vocational institutes as lecturers, advisors and trainers, or become teachers and counsellors after appropriate training. Highly qualified officers can be offered professorships depending on their experience, competence and willingness to integrate fully into the academic world.

There needs to be a ministry-to-ministry understanding and awareness drive, followed by familiarisation visits by the ministry of education and professionals from NCERT, UGC, and vocational institutes to various training establishments and units across the three services. These visits could be coordinated by the directorate of resettlement and would lay the foundation of a long-term relationship between the services and the education sector. The next step would be to identify vacancies and training requirements for integrating servicemen into the sector. Since higher education is being privatised in a big way, bringing the private sector on board is crucial for the success of this initiative. A sustained campaign that revolves around nation-building, influencing younger generations with discipline and commitment, and producing responsible citizens will go a long way in inspiring and motivating ex-servicemen to become teachers, instructors, and professors.

One of the major recommendations of the Sixth Pay Commission was to facilitate lateral transfer of ex-servicemen at all levels into the para-military services and central and state police forces. A similar move into the education sector is worth considering. Embracing such an initiative affords an excellent opportunity in nation-building and inculcating the values of hard work, focus and discipline in the younger generation by veterans from the Armed Forces, at a time when the youth of the country are searching for meaningful direction.

Arjun Subramaniam is a retired air vice marshal and a visiting faculty at Kasturba School of Public Policy, Hyderabad. The views expressed are personal.

ESMAIL BAGHAEI | SPOKESPERSON, FOREIGN MINISTRY, IRAN

Any plan that ... correctly identifies the enemy, has a chance of helping strengthen security and prevent instability (in West Asia)

HT

On the Mecca pact

Assam's floods deserve national calamity status

Every monsoon, India watches Assam disappear beneath water. Images of submerged villages, rescue boats navigating inundated roads, families taking refuge on embankments and wildlife fleeing flooded forests briefly dominate national headlines before attention inevitably shifts elsewhere. Relief is announced, compensation for reconstruction begins, only for the same tragedy to return the following year. The devastating floods of 2026 should force India to confront an uncomfortable truth: Assam's floods are no longer seasonal disasters but a recurring national emergency that deserves recognition as a national calamity.

According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), the 2026 floods have claimed 100 lives to date. Millions were affected during successive waves of flooding, while even after the waters began receding, nearly 18 lakh people across seven districts continued to suffer the consequences. According to Assam's disaster management minister, floods have claimed approximately 836 lives in the state over the past decade. The Union government sanctioned ₹70 crore for relief and rehabilitation, yet emergency assistance cannot substitute for a permanent strategy to address a crisis that repeats itself almost every year.

Climate and geography make it uniquely vulnerable. Nearly 40% of the state's geographical area lies within the Brahmaputra floodplain, accounting for almost one-tenth of India's total flood-prone land. Satellite analysis found that nearly 30% of Assam's land was inundated at least once between 1986 and 2015. These are not isolated disasters but recurring events that shape the state's economy, society, and development trajectory.

The 2026 floods exposed this vulnerability with alarming clarity. Sivasagar and Charaideo emerged among the worst-affected districts after exceptionally heavy rainfall. Assam typically receives between 2,800 and 3,000 millimetres of annual rainfall, nearly 70% of it during the southwest monsoon. This year, prolonged rainfall across upstream catchments, coupled with rising river levels and sediment accumulation in the Brahmaputra, overwhelmed embankments and drainage systems. The disaster was not the result of an extreme event but of multiple interacting climatic and geological pressures.

ASDMA reported 401 houses completely destroyed and another 1,856 partially damaged. Hundreds of kilometres of roads, embankments and public infrastructure require repairs, while 185 livestock deaths

dealt another blow to already vulnerable rural households. Agricultural losses affected thousands of farmers whose incomes depended entirely on a single cropping season. Every flood pushes families deeper into debt, forcing many to rebuild homes and livelihoods with limited financial support.

Flooding is integral to sustaining Kaziranga National Park and Assam's wildlife, yet intense floods also threaten endangered wild life, damage habitats, and disrupt conservation efforts. This year, centuries-old Sanskrit manuscripts in Sivasagar were endangered, illustrating that floods destroy not only infrastructure but also cultural heritage.

Critics argue that granting national calamity status to Assam could encourage similar demands from other disaster-prone states. That concern ignores Assam's exceptional circumstances. The Brahmaputra is a trans-boundary river originating beyond India's borders, carrying enormous sediment loads before traversing one of the world's most fragile floodplains. Managing such a river demands coordinated action involving the Centre, state governments, scientific institutions, and neighbouring countries. No single State possesses the financial or technical capacity to shoulder this responsibility alone.

Recognition must translate into institutional reform. India requires a permanent Brahmaputra Basin Authority with statutory powers over basin-wide planning, sediment management, flood forecasting and riverbank erosion. Investment priorities must shift from annual relief to long-term resilience through elevated infrastructure, climate-resilient housing, wetland restoration, modern forecasting systems and scientific river management. Global evidence shows that investing in resilience before disasters is significantly cheaper than rebuilding after them.

Declaring Assam's floods a national calamity will not prevent the Brahmaputra from overflowing. Rivers cannot be legislated into submission. But such recognition would acknowledge that a disaster recurring every year is no longer merely a state concern. It is a national developmental challenge. India cannot aspire to become a developed nation while accepting the annual devastation of an entire region as inevitable. The true test of disaster governance lies in the foresight to prevent predictable suffering. India has waited for that commitment long enough.

Siddharth Roy is a consultant to the Rashtriya Raksha University under the Union home affairs ministry. The views expressed are personal.

HT
3rd phase of PoK polls held amid rigging allegations
ISLAMABAD: The third phase of elections in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) was held on Monday in four constituencies, amid violence and allegations of rigging. Clashes between Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) and Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) workers were reported in some areas. **PTI**

Ukraine strike on Russia's Tatarstan region kills 13
MOSCOW: A Ukrainian drone strike on the central Russian region of Tatarstan killed at least 13 people. Kyiv said it had struck an oil refinery in the industrial city of Nizhnekamsk, more than 1,000 kilometres away from the Ukrainian border. **AFP**

Ex-Thai MP shoots dead local official over money row
BANGKOK: Chalong Riewrang, a former Thai MP on Monday shot dead a local government official in broad daylight in Nonthaburi province, north of Bangkok over a financial dispute before being arrested and confessing to journalists at the police station. **AFP**

Storms hit China's east, ground nearly 950 Shanghai flights
SHANGHAI: Torrential rain and storms in Typhoon Dolphin's wake inundated several provinces in China's east, as around 950 flights in Shanghai were grounded on Monday due to the weather. **REUTERS**

Trump demands Iran pay compensation for deaths

Reuters
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DUBAI/WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Monday demanded Iran pay compensation for the deaths of people he said it had killed in wars, attacks and protests, raising the rhetorical stakes with Tehran as hopes faded for an imminent deal to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump said he was responding to Iran's earlier call for Washington to meet conditions, including recompensing Tehran for the damage caused in the more than five months since the US and Israel launched strikes on its territory. "I am likewise demanding compensation from Iran, for all of the people that they have killed and gravely wounded with their roadside bombs and many conflicts, for which they are famous," Trump wrote in his Truth Social service.

The abrupt new US demand was not mentioned in any previous talks. Trump said it would be included in all future negotiations with Iran, and would include calls for payments to families of hundreds of thousands of protesters he said Iran had killed. He also suggested Iran should compensate "families of those killed on the USS Cole", a reference to the October 12, 2000, attack on that naval vessel in Yemen which killed 17 US sailors, and has been blamed on Al-Qaeda, not Iran.

Iran had earlier said it was nearing a final pact with Oman defining new shipping lanes between them through the Strait of Hormuz but repeated that the US must meet conditions, including compensation and an end to sanctions and military threats before the key waterway is reopened.

The Strait, through which about a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas flowed prior to the conflict, has been effectively blocked since the US-Israeli attacks on Iran on February 28, pushing up oil prices and inflation.



The graves of children killed during a US strike on the Shajareh Tayebah primary school are pictured at a cemetery in Minab in Iran's Hormozgan province on Monday. **AFP**

tion. Brent crude futures were up \$3.57, or 4.3%, at \$87.13 a barrel by 01:17pm EDT (7:17 GMT), US West Texas Intermediate crude futures were up \$3.36, or 4.5%, at \$81.51.

Trump, who has said the attacks on Iran were aimed at keeping the Islamic Republic from developing nuclear weapons and degrading its ability to threaten the region, is under pressure to end a war that is deeply unpopular at home ahead of mid-term elections in November.

Washington and Tehran agreed to a ceasefire in June, but the US reimposed a blockade on Iranian shipping in the Gulf in July, a move that Tehran said violated the truce, which by then had already broken down.

Iranian strikes on Strait of Hormuz shipping have been coupled with increased attacks by its Yemen-based allies, the Houthis, who have targeted ships at another oil chokepoint on the other side of the Arabian Peninsula between the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden.

The Houthis also declared a naval blockade against Saudi Arabia in the Red Sea last month in response to what they said was a Saudi siege on them in Yemen, an allegation denied by Riyadh, which backs Yemen's internationally recognised government.

Mojtaba makes six new military appointments

TEHRAN: Iran's Supreme Leader Mohsen Rezaei has made six new appointments to the Revolutionary Guards and armed forces, including Major General Pilot Ali Abdollahi as chief of staff of the armed forces and Brigadier General Ahmad Vahidi as commander-in-chief of the IRGC, according to a written message carried on Mojtaba's social media accounts.

Abdollahi had previously led the Khatam Al-Anbiya, Iran's inter-branch central military command tasked with coordinating operations. A statement on Khamenei's website announced that "Major General Ali Abdollahi has been appointed chief of staff of the armed forces. Brigadier General Ahmad Vahidi has also been appointed Commander-in-Chief of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps with the rank of major general."

The pair represent Khamenei's first senior military appointments since being named supreme leader early in the Middle East war after the death of his father in US-Israeli

OMAN: GROUNDED TANKER OIL SPILL COVERS 390 SQ KM
MUSCAT: Leaking crude oil from a tanker grounded off a nature reserve in Oman has created a slick covering some 390 square kilometres, the country's government said on Monday. The Caroline Bezeqi is loaded with close to a million barrels of Russian oil bound for Asia and first reported difficulties on June 8 off Yemen, with two maritime security sources saying initial assessments indicated a spill had occurred aboard. No party has taken responsibility for attacking the vessel. **REUTERS**

US announces fee for H1-B, L-1 visa extensions from Sep 9

Press Trust of India
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WASHINGTON: The US on Monday published new rules that would require large employers to pay a fee of \$4,000 for H-1B and \$4,500 for L-1 applications for extension of visas for their employees. Earlier, these fees were applicable only for initial H-1B and L-1 petitions or if the applicants changed jobs.

Major Indian IT services and consulting providers rely on a blended onshore-offshore staffing model, bringing them within the ambit of the changed rule. The 9-11 Response and Biometric Entry-Exit Fee, applicable to employers with 50 or more employees in the US or more than 50% in H-1B or L-1 non-immigrant status, will come into effect

from September 9, the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) said. The rule is likely to increase immigration sponsorship costs for technology companies, global consulting firms, IT services providers, multinational employers, and other organisations with a large number of H-1B and L-1 employees. Organisations filing routine extension requests for the same employee will now face additional filing costs that previously may not have applied. DHS clarified that amended petitions that do not request an extension of status are exempt from the expanded fee requirement. DHS estimates that closing this administrative gap and collecting \$4,000 to \$4,500 on every extension petition will generate approximately \$15.7 billion annually.

U.S. STATE DEPT: REVOKED OVER 175,000 VISAS

WASHINGTON: The US State Department said on Monday it has revoked more than 175,000 visas from foreign nationals under President Donald Trump's administration, as it continues a sweeping immigration crackdown that has stripped travel and immigration privileges from tens of thousands more people. It said the revocations targeted foreigners who "violated the terms of their visas, committed crimes, called for violence against US citizens, defrauded Americans, abused our immigration system, or endangered national security". **REUTERS**

INDIA CONDEMNS DEFACTO OF ITS EMBASSY IN SLOVENIA

NEW DELHI: India on Monday condemned the defacing of its embassy in Slovenia, purportedly by pro-Khalistan elements, and called on Slovenian authorities to hold the perpetrators accountable. "We condemn the defacement of the premises of our embassy in Ljubljana, Slovenia, by anti-India elements," the external affairs ministry said in a statement without giving details of who was responsible for the incident. People familiar with the matter said pro-Khalistan elements were behind the defacing of the embassy with anti-India slogans.

The external affairs ministry said that under the Vienna Convention, diplomatic premises are "inviolable and must be protected". The Indian side has taken up the "matter strongly" with Slovenian authorities in New Delhi and in Ljubljana so that "the perpetrators behind such reprehensible acts are held accountable". **HTC**

Oceans hit record-high temperatures in July

Agence France-Presse
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PARIS: World's oceans hit record-high temperatures for a second straight month in July, driven by marine heatwaves around Europe and a powerful El Niño taking shape in the Pacific, the EU's global warming monitor Copernicus said on Monday.

Global average sea surface temperatures in July were 20.96°C, beating the previous record of 20.89°C in 2023. Copernicus director Carlo Buontempo said parts of the Mediterranean and Atlantic were unusually warm but the developing El Niño "is probably the driving force" behind the record sea temperatures. "We are now facing a very large El Niño — possibly unprecedented in terms of amplitude. It is clear that the contribution coming from the tropical Pacific becomes quite important," the climate scientist told reporters on August 5.

El Niño is the warm phase of a natural climate cycle that temporarily raises ocean temperatures in the tropical Pacific and can influence weather extremes like drought and floods around the world. It also adds heat to a planet already warmed from burning fossil fuels. El Niño events typically peak at the end of a year before heat is released from the ocean into the atmosphere, pushing up global temperatures. The last El Niño helped make 2023 and 2024 the second- and first-hottest years on record, respectively. Buontempo said scientists expect a new record for global average temperatures later this year or early 2027. Globally, last month was the joint second-warmest July on record with an average surface air temperature 1.47°C above the 1850-1900 pre-industrial benchmark, Copernicus said. The last 11 years have been the hottest on record and "we have not seen a climate that warm during our lifetime, and very possibly our civilisation", Buontempo said.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Without Bumrah, India must discover new bowling identity

This attack may require more from Siraj, more overs from the spinners and greater flexibility in their approach

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KOLKATA: There was a phase at Eden Gardens last November that best explains Jasprit Bumrah's value to India better than any statistic.

South Africa had begun the first Test briskly. The score had moved to 57 without loss and the pitch, despite pre-match anxiety about its character, did not appear to have persuaded the visitors to go into survival mode.

Then Bumrah intervened. Dismissing two set openers in consecutive overs, Bumrah finished with 5/27 by the time South Africa were bowled out for 159.

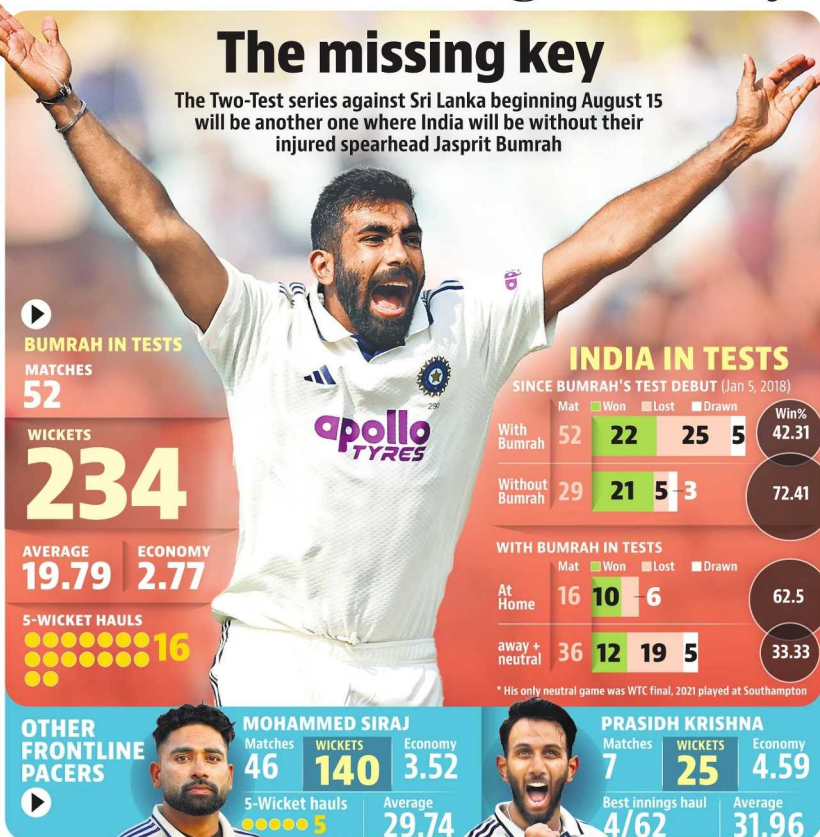
Once again, India had been provided headway into a Test by a bowler who could make a pitch look more helpful than it was, turn pressure into wickets and change the direction of an innings almost by himself.

Bumrah did something similar, if less spectacular, in Guwahati a week later. He bowled 32 overs for 75 runs and took two wickets in a South African first innings that eventually reached 489. The wickets were not enough to prevent India's 2-0 series defeat, but his bowling illustrated the other part of Bumrah's value—even when he wasn't ripping through a batting order, he could make scoring difficult for the batsmen and change the direction of an innings almost by himself.

Bumrah has been ruled out of the two-Test series, leaving Mohammed Siraj as the senior member of a pace group that also contains Prasidh Krishna and Gurnoor Brar. The squad was originally selected with Bumrah, Siraj, Krishna and Brar as its seam options, but now India are being forced to rethink merely personnel but the way the attack itself is supposed to function. That distinction could have repercussions on how India's bowling fronts out in the future.

Bumrah is unique and hence irreplaceable. Which is why India need an attack that can compensate for the things Bumrah made look routine. Siraj, in particular, inherits a different responsibility. When Bumrah was present, Siraj could be the aggressor, the bowler willing to rump and hit the pitch hard, knowing that the world's most complete fast bowler was waiting at the other end.

In Sri Lanka, Siraj becomes the senior seamer. He will have to create pressure rather than



merely contribute to it. That could make India's bowling more collective—and perhaps more demanding of everyone involved. The spinners are likely to carry a greater share of the short burst of three or four sharp overs, a change of angle, a return with the old ball, another spell when a partnership begins to develop.

Without him, India may have to think in terms of longer chunks of pressure. Like if Siraj holds one end, a second seamer attacks in shorter spells, and the spinners squeeze from the other end. Essentially, it's less about finding one match-winner and more

about ensuring that somebody is always asking a question. And in Sri Lanka, more often than not it's always a spinner. Which makes the just-announced warmup game a near-ideal rehearsal for India because the pitch started out to be flat but then turned later. "The bowlers had a great opportunity to go down and express themselves on a pitch which was slightly on a flatter side in the first day. But as the days went by, there was more turn on it and definitely a good outing for the spinners," said Sajit Bahutia, India's bowling coach, after the warm-up match on Sunday.

"Most of the guys have come here, experienced guys, Jaddu (Jadeja) has already played here. But the new guys like Manav and a few others, Saransh Jain, they need to just adapt to what will be the ideal lengths and obviously the field sets, which is very much important." With Ravichandran Ashwin already retired and Bumrah needing more rest than ever, it's not a secret that India have to urgently remodel their bowling strategy. This attack may require more from Siraj, more overs from the spinners and greater flexibility in their approach.

Ayush ready for tough Worlds opener vs top seed Shi Yu Qi

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MUMBAI: The journey to success, especially in sports, is somewhat easier when there have been trailblazers, someone whose footsteps can be followed. For India, the path to the podium has long been set in the World Championships—the country has won gold, four silver and 10 bronze medals at the elite competition across disciplines over the years. Some of the biggest names in the sport have set those yardsticks. But Ayush Shetty, the 21-year-old rising star who competes in his debut World Championships in New Delhi starting on August 17, is not looking at those achievements.

"I don't see it as a benchmark to chase," he said during a virtual interview on Monday. "I'm not focusing on what others have done—they are legends of the game. I have been focusing more on myself, playing better and winning matches. I would like to set my own benchmark."

It's a bold statement by a player who transitioned into the senior circuit less than three years ago. He has already shown that he is capable of producing big wins. In April, a month short of his 21st birthday, the boy from Karnataka became the first Indian man to reach the singles



Ayush Shetty. HT ARCHIVES

final at the Badminton Asia Championships in 2024, taking the silver medal. He became the youngest Indian male to stand on the podium at the continental event. A month after that achievement in Ningbo, China, he won four of his five matches to help the Indian team claim bronze at the Thomas Cup. These were performances that took him as high as No. 18 in the world rankings, but also gave him a confidence boost for tackling life on the professional tour. "When I entered the senior circuit, playing against the top 20 players was a great challenge," Shetty said. "Matching the pace was really tough, but I think I've adapted to it and I can push opponents and play at their pace."

His belief has grown with the performances. The run to the final in Ningbo saw him beat fifth seed Li Shifeng, world No. 20 Chi Yu Jen, world No. 3 Jonathan Christie and then world No. 1 Kianurik Vikarn. In the final, he lost to current world No. 1 Shi Yu Qi. That was Shetty's third loss in three matches against the Chinese player. He is now gearing up for the silver medal, after being drawn to face the tournament favourite in the opening round of the World Championships. "I was watching the (draw) live and as soon as I got Shi... I was ready to face anyone. I was unseeded, so I was prepared to even play the world No. 1," Shetty said. "It's just another match and it'll be a tough battle. I've got better (since the last meeting) and I'll be better prepared this time." Since May, he has been working to develop his game, focusing specifically on the "physical and tactical aspects."

"We've been working on being more accurate on the shots as well, and it's been going really well," he added.

It's a rather difficult hurdle he faces in his first senior World Championship match. But the player who stands 6'5" has been expected to do great things in the sport by Danish great Viktor Axelsen and PV Sindhu, who is the only Indian to have won gold at the Worlds.

ICC criticised for WC format changes
DUBAI: Cricket Scotland and the Royal Dutch Cricket Association (KNCB) said the changes to next year's ODI World Cup format "risk weakening the integrity and credibility of international cricket", questioning the process through which the changes have been introduced. While the 2027 ODI World Cup will have a total of 14 countries, the teams ranked 12th, 13th and 14th will face off in a qualifying round from which only one team will progress to join the final 12 sides.

High jumper Pooja ends 7th in WA U20
EUGENE: National senior record holder high jumper Pooja Singh failed to live up to the expectations, finishing seventh in the final, as India ended their World Athletics U20 campaign with three medals. The 19-year-old Pooja could clear 1.84m, while Liliana Batori (1.90m) of Hungary and Aitana Alonso (1.90m) of Spain bagged the silver and bronze medals, respectively.

{ **BADMINTON WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS** } CAPITAL GETS TOURNAMENT READY

Preventive measures: Langur mimics to keep monkeys off Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium

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NEW DELHI: Monkey business had left Indian authorities and badminton officials embarrassed in January during the India Open after monkeys strayed into the playing hall and pigeon droppings fell on the court during matches. Enter the langur mimics. To prevent any such disruptions during the BWF World Championships starting here on August 17, officials have hired men who mimic the sound of an angry langur to chase away monkeys from the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium premises.

Besides barking out an elaborate renovation of the venue, the langur mimics summoned will use nothing but their vocal cords and a basic understanding of primate psychology to keep the monkeys at bay. This is the bizarre yet entertaining world of the national capital's "monkey whisperers". The men are hired to stand outside offices or sporting arenas and make the aggressive langur noise.

At the IG Stadium, this task has been entrusted to Jabbar and colleagues. On Monday, Jabbar demonstrated the sound he will use to give monkeys the impression that a langur is on the prowl.

"It's not just me. There are two other guys with me," Jabbar told reporters. "When we make

these calls, monkeys just run away. We also ensure that the bushes and make the langur sound to chase away the monkeys. We time the mimicking accordingly. This vocal method is quite effective." The timing, Jabbar says, is everything to get the monkeys to scramble for the boundary wall.

The langur mimics are paid between ₹20,000 and ₹25,000 per assignment. "Getting employment is not consistent, but we do keep getting work from time to time. There are many of us who do it," says Jabbar.

Using these men started once law prohibited the use of langurs



Bodhana Sivanandan (l) and Shreyas Royal.

Royal, Bodhana give British chess the Indian touch

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BENGALURU: Eight years ago, Shreyas Royal was on the verge of being deported from the UK with his family after his father's work visa was due to expire and he did not meet the annual income requirement for renewal. The family was later informed by the Home Office that they would be allowed to remain in the UK keeping in mind Shreyas' exceptional talent.

In 2024, Shreyas became the UK's youngest-ever grandmaster. On Sunday, the 17-year-old won the British Chess Championship at the University of Warwick in Coventry, finishing ahead of seasoned names such as Luke McShane and nine-time champion Michael Adams.

When coronavirus was sweeping the world six years ago, Bodhana Sivanandan found a chess set among belongings a family friend gave her parents before returning to India.

On Sunday, Bodhana became the youngest-ever woman's winner at the British Chess Championship. She is 11. Two Indian-origin players are vying out the future of British chess.

Bodhana has already shattered several records: she became the youngest female player to score a Woman Grandmaster norm (at 10); and the youngest person selected for England's team at the 2024 Chess Olympiad.

Over the last decade, on Sunday, she broke Elaine Pritchard's record, who won the British women's Championships in 1939, aged 13.

Bodhana is already the British Blitz and Rapid Champion.

This classical title now gives her an incredible title crown. On Sunday, dressed in a grey sweatshirt, jeans and a powder-pink headband, Bodhana started down her opponent, fellow Indian-origin player and Ireland's first woman grandmaster, Trisha Kanyanarala, through her glasses. They were locked in a Rapid playoff for the title.

Up against the clock, Bodhana, playing White, kept finding the right moves with little trouble.

As White, she spurned an offer to trade queens while closing in on Black's shaky king. Trisha resigned soon after, and Bodhana, who not too long ago needed a booster seat to reach the table, shook hands with her opponent and left the board without betraying any emotion.

"She doesn't take her wins too seriously, nor do losses break her. At home, we make it a point not to have an extreme reaction to her results," her father, Sivanandan, originally from Trichy, Tamil Nadu, told HT in an earlier interview.

On Sunday, Bodhana became the youngest-ever woman's winner at the British Chess Championship in the sixth round. She had earlier recorded an impressive win over grandmaster Amari Ghazi. After seven rounds, Royal, who was born in Bengaluru, was in sole lead with six points. He drew against Adams in the penultimate round and wrapped up the title with a final-round win over Harry Grieve.

Royal later said he had been hoping the tournament would not go to a playoff because his energy levels were running low. It didn't come to pass.

Together with Bodhana, Royal, who has been supported by Google DeepMind's Denny Hassabis, shook up the century-old Championships last weekend.

Led by two Indian-origin stars, British chess is indeed entering a new era.



IGI Stadium ready for BWF World Championships. SANCHEZ KHANNAH

male during displays to show dominance, and the angry sound—guttural, short and sharp. During the Commonwealth Games here in 2020, langurs were used by the Wildlife Protection Act, which meant they cannot be kept captive, owned privately, or hired out for guard duty. As langurs make different calls to reflect their mood or the situation, this includes loud whoops by

When the Parliament is in session, the noise hides among the bushes and make the langur sound to chase away the monkeys. For years, trained grey langurs were used by the Wildlife Protection Act, which meant they cannot be kept captive, owned privately, or hired out for guard duty. As langurs make different calls to reflect their mood or the situation, this includes loud whoops by

To chase away the pigeons, a sound-emitting machine from the USA has been imported. Non-toxic, pigeon-repellent gel has also been applied across the rafters. The roof has been water-proofed to prevent leaks and the large number of toilets refurbished.

West Delhi cruise to eight-wicket win against East Delhi

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: West Delhi Lions registered a convincing eight-wicket victory over East Delhi Riders in a rain-curtalled Delhi Premier League (DPL) 2026 fixture at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Monday. After the rain interruption, the Lions were set a revised target of 58 runs from seven overs, which they chased down comfortably in just 4.1 overs.

Batting first, East Delhi Riders were reduced to 95/5 in 15 overs before rain brought the innings to a halt. The Riders suffered an early blow as Dhruv Kaushik was dismissed off the very first ball.

However, Arpit Rana and Sujal Singh steadied the innings with a valuable 53-run partnership. Rana played an attacking knock of 32 off 20 balls before his dismissal triggered another collapse, with the Riders losing wickets at regular intervals. Sujal also chipped in with 34 off 22 balls before being dismissed.

For West Delhi Lions, Mayank Gusan led the bowling



Krish Yadav. DOCA

effort with 2/16 in three overs, while Shubham Dubey also picked up 2/17 in three overs.

Chasing the revised target, the Lions lost Ankit Kumar early for 4 off 3 balls. However, his dismissal did little to trouble the chase as Krish Yadav and Jitesh Singh took control of the innings.

Krish was particularly aggressive, taking the attack to the Riders' bowlers and remaining unbeaten on 34 off just 14 balls. His quickfire knock ensured that West Delhi Lions completed the chase with plenty of balls to spare.

How a leaner, meaner Sakshi packed a punch

Shantanu Srivastava

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NEW DELHI: A little over a month before the selection trials for the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games in May, boxer Sakshi Chaudhary called coach Chhotu Lal Yadav at the Army Sports Institute (ASI) in Pune with a potentially career-altering request.

"She wanted to cut weight," Yadav said. "It's a line a coach dreads because we know how excruciating it is for an athlete. And here she was, almost volunteering to go through the grind."

Having boxed all her senior career in 54kg, moving down a category wasn't an easy choice for Sakshi. Preeti Pawar, by virtue of winning the 2020 Asian Championships, had already booked her CWG and Asian Games berth in the 54kg division while Jaimee Lamboria occupied the 57kg class.

"With a maintenance weight of 55kgs, it would've been better for me to gain weight. Once your body is used to a certain kind of training and diet, it becomes tough to trick the body. I opted to go to 51kg after a lengthy discussion with Yadav sir," Sakshi said.

Yadav, who has coached boxing legend MC Mary Kom in the past, was ready. "I knew it was the right call. Preeti is a stronger boxer than her, and I thought Sakshi could make use of her height in the 51kg division. Jaimee is the 51kg division. We didn't want to touch her," he said.

The lowest Olympic weight class in India is stacked — there's two-time world champion Nikhat Zareen, 48kg world champion Minakshi Hooda, and former CWG and world champion Nitu Ganghans.

"I knew if I could beat them in trials, I'll win the gold at CWG. They are all high-quality boxers," said Sakshi, who eventually won the gold in Glasgow.

The genesis of that success, she agrees, lay in that sweaty, stifling boxing hall in NIS Patiala where she stunned Nikhat 4-1 in the semi-final before beating Minakshi — she had beaten Nitu in her semi-final — 5-0 in the decider.

"Very rarely do you get such competition at home. My weight class had three world champions, and I beat two of

Timely stoop to conquer

The young boxer was one of India's five women boxing gold medalists at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games, after dropping to a lower division

Know Sakshi Chaudhary

AGE: 22

FROM: Bhiwani, Haryana

STYLE: Orthodox

WEIGHT CATEGORY: 51kg

EMPLOYER: Indian Army

Major achievements

2026
GOLD AT COMMONWEALTH GAMES

2025
GOLD AT WORLD BOXING CUP

2021
Bronze at Asian Championships



them. When you beat someone like Nikhat, it obviously gives you a lot of confidence," she said.

Captain Yadav knew his ward stood a fair chance in the high-quality trial. "Nikhat hadn't been at her best over the past few months. I think she loses a lot of her strength when she cuts weight unlike Sakshi who retains her strength. Also, she has the advantage of reach which she put to good use against Nikhat," he said.

Former women's team coach Bhaskar Bhatt agreed. Having seen the current bunch of women boxers during his tenure with the senior team (2021-2023), Bhatt believes Sakshi should stick to her new weight division.

"It's the kind of competition we've been missing in India for a while," Bhatt said. "Sakshi's weight cut was very scientific because in Glasgow she never looked out of breath. Her footwork was fast, and she had

great rhythm in her punches. She moved well in the ring and never stopped punching."

Sakshi's month-long stint in ASI Pune was "a bit of a test case" for Yadav. He set Sakshi a target of losing 500gm each week, trained her all days of the week with six days dedicated to tactical and technical aspects, and changed her diet completely. All the primary sources of carbohydrates were off the plate, as was her favourite churma.

"Boxers from Haryana rely a lot on churma and taking that out of her diet was toughest. Her diet was built around protein sources to ensure she didn't lose lean muscle," Yadav informed.

The result was a leaner, meaner Sakshi who glided across the ring with ease. "Lower weights demand excellent footwork, and Sakshi was up to the task in Glasgow. There are a few areas that she needs to work on, such as boxing from

close quarters. She tends to clinch, and use her elbows to push the opponent to wriggle out. All these things go against you," Bhatt explained.

Yadav and Sakshi will have to iron out the flaws leading up to the Asian Games where sterner tests await. South Korea, Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan and China have been the traditional powerhouses at the continental level and are likely to give the Indian contingent a tough workout.

"The competition at the Asian Games will be nowhere close to what they got in Glasgow. But if Sakshi can work on a few areas, she can go deep at the Asian Games. If guided well, she can be a contender at the LA Olympics as well," Bhatt added.

With the national camp having started on Monday, Sakshi will have just about a month to shake off the Glasgow afterglow and get her focus back. "That won't be a problem. CWG is over, and it's time to aim higher," she said.



PM Narendra Modi with Lovlina Borgohain at his residence. PMO

PM Modi lauds athletes' efforts at Glasgow CWG

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi felicitated India's CWG contingent, congratulating them for the medal haul in Glasgow and calling them an inspiration for the new generation. He had a candid conversation with the athletes and shared some lighter moments as well.

India won 39 medals at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, including 13 gold, 17 silver and nine bronze. Despite a curtailed sports programme, India finished fourth on the medal table. Athletics and para-athletics, boxing, weightlifting and judo contributed the bulk of India's medals.

PM Modi hosted a reception for them on Sunday. Union Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, Minister of State for Sports Raksha Khadse and Indian Olympic Association president PT Usha were also present. "I have been staying here for 12-13 years. If I have regularly met anyone, received anyone, it's our athletes. You have consistently made India proud at the international level with your courage and determination. You have been achieving new heights. Your medals will inspire our children," Modi told the CWG medalists.

Conversing with Mirabai Chanu, who won a record third gold medal at the CWG, Modi said, "You were in tears on the podium and it felt as if with every drop, a gold medal was dripping."

To this, Chanu replied, "Sir, I was very happy that day. I was crying because I could not win a medal at the Paris Olympics — I fell behind by just one kg. As an athlete, you go through so much. In these four years, I faced so many injuries, then there were family problems, so it has been a very difficult period. So when I stood on the podium and saw the Tricolour

going up and heard the National Anthem, I just could not stop myself. Tears kept flowing," said Chanu, the Tokyo Olympics silver medalist.

Modi lauded another Olympic medalist, Lovlina Borgohain, who won silver in the 75kg weight category, for having the courage to point out a distorted map of India at a restaurant in Glasgow, which has now gone viral. Lovlina, who hails from Assam, was surprised to see the northeastern part of the country missing from the map of India and spoke to the staff.

"What happened? You were fighting with the restaurant guys," Modi smiled and asked Lovlina. "After a very good performance, when we had won so many medals, we had gone there on the last day. I felt bad after seeing the map and politely told them about it. They agreed and changed it," Lovlina said.

"Even in such circumstances, when one is in a jubilant mood and celebrating with the team, it is significant that you noticed the distorted map and immediately stood up and spoke. Not only do you stand on the podium to win medals for the country, but the feeling and pride you have for your country show everywhere. This act of yours will be remembered for a long time," the PM replied.

Modi also hailed boxer Jadumani Singh for dedicating his medal to the Armed Forces. On July 26, the day of Vijay Diwas, Jadumani beat a Pakistani boxer and later dedicated the victory to the Indian Army.

"On Vijay Diwas, I was fighting a boxer from Pakistan. I am from the Indian Army and I wanted to win that day. I beat him overwhelmingly and dedicated to the Indian Army," said Jadumani. "The way you expressed yourself, dedicating it to the victory of the Kargil War, has made your victory even bigger," the PM said.

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